IN THE SHADOW OF WAR

The United States Since the 1930s

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Moral Equivalents of War

When George Bush declared a drug war, he was no innovator. The Jamesian search for a moral equivalent of war was an old tradition in America, one renewed by Reagan among others, especially when he addressed drugs and crime. In 1981, Reagan praised police chiefs "who command the front lines in America's battle for public order" and "the thin blue line that holds back a jungle which threatens to reclaim the clearing we call civilization," language evoking frontier mythology about whites conquering and civilizing the American West. "This administration hereby declares an all-out war on big-time organized crime and the drug racketeers," he announced in his 1983 State of the Union address. "The war against drugs is a war of individual battles," he added in 1988.[28] Indeed, by the time of Bush's 1989 announcement, the drug war had been so often and loudly declared that citizens might wonder when it began or might end. The search for war's equivalent thus preceded Bush's presidency, but climaxed during it in part because of his more acerbic and uneven leadership and because of the Cold War's end.

Use of the war metaphor was also now more diverse in sources and promiscuous in application than in the 1960s, when it had emanated primarily from the White House. Presidents now had limited control over it. They might jump-start it in specific cases, as with drugs, but ignore it in others, as in the "war on AIDS," or find it turned against them. No single political force conceived it; Reagan and Bush simply revealed one way to exploit it. Although the rhetoric sometimes proclaimed a campaign *by* Americans against some national problem, it more often signaled, sometimes intentionally, conflict *among* Americans. As such it traced and propelled the continuing inward turn of militarization, as its energies and institutions shifted toward Americans' conflicts with each other and away from the Soviet-American struggle. To be sure, that formulation is maddeningly vague about causation—no sentient being, militarization could not "turn" anywhere. As at its start, so too now: many forces and circumstances redirected it.

Among those was the outlook of many conservatives in the Reagan era. Since they presented the sources of national strength as more cultural than military and economic—a matter of internal cohesion more than power abroad—they raised the premium on fighting out and overcoming internal divisions. The decisive war was at home; once won, victory abroad would follow. By the same token, as prospects for serious war abroad receded, the search for a substitute at home intensified among a people so accustomed to war of some sort that its cessation seemed almost unimaginable, to conservatives and to many other Americans. The "wars" that ensued were varied, fascinating, and often baleful in their consequences.

One waged early in the decade was against terrorism. The Iran hostage affair had highlighted it; other incidents, usually in the Middle East, followed. This

war proved hard for Reagan to declare and sustain, however, despite likening himself to cinema's Rambo. In 1981, he compared the struggle against terrorism to the Allied effort against Nazi genocide but admitted that terrorism, "scattered through the world," was "not quite large enough in dimension for us to rally behind as we once did in that war."[29] Lack of victory was also a reason not to trumpet this war. Instead it became a secret war waged by the illegal methods exposed as the Iran-Contra affair. In the end, Reagan surrendered rather than wage this war; bribery to get hostages released was not a bellicose policy. There was another reason this war was a nonstarter: it drew too little on the passions Americans felt about each other.

This feckless war, like the long war on drugs, indicated that the line between real and metaphorical wars was blurry, since the latter did embrace elements of real war: guns were fired, troops deployed, and people killed in such causes, in alarming numbers as the drug war went on. Blurry, the line was still recognizable. Few people argued (although Reagan did try) that these wars were the literal equivalent of others the United States had waged—World War II, for example—or current wars raging elsewhere, as in Afghanistan, where thousands died in combat.

At the same time, however, metaphorical wars with staying power had to partake *something* of war's death and passion. Not every public issue would qualify. No war was declared in behalf of education, although Education Secretary Terrel Bell argued that "if an unfriendly foreign power had attempted to impose on America the mediocre educational performance that exists today, we might have viewed it as an act of war." Reagan presumably waged a "war on waste" in government, as a presidential commission chaired by Peter Grace titled its report, but the enemy was too abstract.[30] Too, the notion was an oxymoron: since by nature war is a wasteful activity that enlarges government, to wage war on governmental waste was silly. By the same token, no "war on the federal deficit" emerged, although politicians of all stripes labeled the deficit a major problem. Not only was the enemy again abstract, few politicians seriously sought to defeat it. Metaphorical wars required political payoff if politicians were to declare them.

At first glance, America's "trade war" confronted similar obstacles: "trade" was an abstraction, and the dull complexities of economics did not easily generate public passion. Still, this label stuck; the metaphor was ubiquitous, its implications and imagery widely elaborated. In part it stuck because America's trade deficit seemed to have more obvious results than the fiscal deficit: shuttered factories, ruined cities, discarded workers, and foreign goods were the visible casualties and weapons. More than that, it was closely associated with Japan, America's old *war* enemy and racial competitor. Trade with many countries—including West Germany, another wartime enemy—swelled the trade deficit, just as other nations' investors, British and Dutch for example, bought up

American properties as aggressively, if more quietly. But Japan loomed largest in that deficit—the singular enemy in most renderings of the "trade war."

Given its resonance with World War II and that war's racial antagonisms, the trade war readily took passionate form. In political rhetoric, everyday complaints, and media culture, an acute sense emerged that the United States and Japan really *were* at war, even if no guns were yet fired. Thus Howard Baker, a leading Republican, used the fortieth anniversary of the end of World War II to insist that "we're still at war with Japan" and "we're losing"; a senator characterized Japan's export of cars to the United States as "an economic Pearl Harbor"; and a White House staffer urged that "the next time B-52s fly over Tokyo . . . we better make sure they carry bombs." Desperate American competitors exploited that outlook. Buick featured a photograph of MacArthur's receipt of Japan's surrender on the battleship *Missouri* above the words: "ONCE AGAIN, THE JAPANESE MUST COME TO TERMS WITH AN AMERICAN LEADER." (The imagery probably meant little to younger Americans, but they were not Buick's target market.) After 1989, a string of fiftieth-year anniversaries of World War II events supplied new opportunities to attach war's imagery and ugliness to Japanese-American economic relations, giving the trade war life into the 1990s when other metaphorical wars faded away. Freer in form and content, political cartoons exposed this outlook baldly. The *Atlanta Constitution* equated "Japan Bombs Pearl Harbor" with "Japan Buys Pearl Harbor" by keeping the typeface and words of its mock 1941 and 1989 front pages almost identical, as if World War II still raged, with only a minor change in wording (see fig. 10). Such cartoons suggested that Japan was an unchanging enemy, that only its devious tactics had altered, and that it again earned American vengeance, though how to inflict it remained elusive. They set up reassuring expectations—America would triumph in this war as in the last one—but also undercut them: maybe this time the United States was surrendering.[31]

As in World War II, Americans did not alone set the tone of the interchange. For many Japanese, too, talk of trade war reawakened images of real war, prompted renewed claims about America's sloth and racial impurity, and stirred dreams of redeeming Japan's humiliation in 1945. Japanese competed better, argued one official in 1982, because they "are a race of completely pure blood, not a mongrelized race as in the United States." The military balance between the two nations was far different than in 1941, to the point that during the Gulf War one American expert derided Japan's "infantile fear of war"—a remarkable criticism given American insistence on Japan's demilitarization after 1945—and Japanese conservatives praised "Americans for possessing a 'samurai spirit' lacking in Japan." But such language still drew on the images of World War II, simply inverting them—Japan now soft and squeamish about war, the United States "a war-loving, sloganeering, extremist country" fitting, John Dower noted, America's "World War II images of Japan." No wonder,

James Fallows reported, that "Japan's opinion-making class," eyeing Pearl Harbor's fiftieth anniversary, "prepared the public to cringe in dread of U.S. outbursts this month."[32]

The old war entwined with the new one in other ways. In Hawaii, some Americans (usually tourists, not Hawaiians) continued to resent the presence of numerous Japanese investors and tourists, regarding it as a sign that Japan had won the war by other means or threatened the "physical defilement" of the sacred site of Pearl Harbor. Other Americans met Japanese there in a spirit of reconciliation but, sensing ugly feelings, the National Park Service's acting director thought an official invitation for Japan's participation in the fiftieth-anniversary commemoration of the Pearl Harbor attack would be "inappropriate, possibly offensive, and fraught with problems and incalculable indelicacies." The president of the Pearl Harbor Survivors Association had a cruder response: "Would you expect the Jews to invite the Nazis to an event where they were talking about the Holocaust?" That anniversary stirred up more images linking the old war of combat with the new one of trade. The *Chicago Tribune*'s dissonant treatment caught the conflicting emotions: on December 7, 1991, it featured a cartoon of a sunken battleship at Pearl Harbor with the words "we remember"—above an editorial captioned "Looking Beyond Pearl Harbor." Months later, fifty years after internment camps for Japanese-Americans opened, one cartoonist compared Japan-bashing in 1992 to wartime American attitudes.[33]

This was such volatile stuff that national leaders usually tiptoed around the war metaphor, lest they disrupt the delicate ballet of Japanese-American negotiations on a host of matters. In the drug war, Presidents issued ringing calls to arms. In the trade war, the metaphor bubbled up more from below—from aspirants to rather than holders of high office (despite some indelicate remarks), from middling politicians exploiting the plight of congressional districts losing the war, from ad agencies and cartoonists who sensed the popular passions involved, from ordinary Americans, however many Japanese products they bought.

The trade war revealed another source of the metaphorical wars: the continuing hold of World War II on Americans' imaginations. Only the Civil War's grip had lingered so long, until weakened by World War I. No comparable event (although the Cold War's end came close) came fifty years after Pearl Harbor. Overwhelmingly, the images, reference points, and models cited for war's moral equivalents of the 1980s ran back to World War II, or to its aftermath and its legacy of nuclear weapons. It was as if Americans had no other benchmark against which to measure themselves and their challenges, their militarized culture looking more to past triumphs than to future glories.

World War II did not alone account for Japanese and American images of each other. "Why," an American once asked, "do so many Americans, after witnessing the devastation and futility of war, continue to think of Japan and the Japanese in terms of war? Why have so many Japanese a similar mental attitude toward the United States?" Franklin Roosevelt raised those questions in 1923. "It is natural for the language of war to be applied to the battlefields of commerce," John Dower has argued. "There is not, after all, an infinite variety of lively words to go around." In fact, others were imaginable—from sports, for example, which had long supplied Americans' metaphors for war—but the trade war's language was "historically specific . . . the rhetoric of World War II," albeit set in a longer record of Japanese-American hostility.[34]

That war's hold, remarkable in longevity, was in other ways unsurprising. World War II ushered in the peak of America's global power and domestic affluence. Since America's ensuing wars in Korea and Vietnam were hardly attractive replacements—and since any imaginable big war in the future would be a nuclear conflict—World War II was left as "the only appropriate model for 'all-out' war metaphors." Among past and prospective wars, it alone offered the attractive combination of giant scale, moral clarity, American unity, and total American victory. Beneath the surface of 1980s rhetoric, other wars did rumble. Like Vietnam, the drug war lacked clear battlefronts, bled America slowly, and saw victory promised but never achieved. As the *Nation* noted, "Sending advisers to Peru recalls widening the war into Cambodia; stressing the number of people put behind bars sounds like body counts." Or in the different comparison to the Vietnam War offered by *Soldier of Fortune* magazine, the drug war is one "in which Bleeding Hearts pity the drug dealers and gang members. . . . It's a war where the police, as the soldiers of the streets, aren't given the opportunity to win." Vietnam's undertow was one reason that the metaphorical wars of the 1980s, especially those proclaimed by Presidents, often came to seem dispiriting and divisive. It was also a reason to keep drawing from the deep wells of World War II.[35]

Despite the trade war, the greatest passions were usually reserved for "wars" that engaged Americans' feelings about each other, not distant enemies. The drug war did so. It did occasionally feature external foes like Cuba's Castro, Panama's Noriega, and mysterious Columbian cartels. But more alarming for many Americans were the enemies in their midst: briefly in the 1980s, cocaine-snorting white "yuppies"; more often, inner-city black and Hispanic men, the urban gangs they joined, and the addicted mothers they failed to marry, with their drug-crippled or AIDS-infected babies. On occasion, conservatives drew wider circles encompassing all those defeatists who did not see a rosy future emerging from America's military and moral revival. "The same people who winked at us about drugs also told us that America's future was bleak," Reagan told Americans in 1988, and "said that the traditional values of family and community were old fashioned and out of date. It was as if they'd lost faith in the future and wanted the rest of us to lose it, too."[36] The harder divisions, however, involved race, ethnicity, and social class.

As with the war metaphor generally, drug war rhetoric was ostensibly de-

signed to unite Americans. "As in World War II, I am convinced that the war on drugs will not be won until we mobilize the American public," argued one congressman wanting "drug war bonds" to finance the cause (the Bush White House demurred).[37] That reasoning drew on powerful memories of war as a unifying force, but the memories were rose-tinted: Americans had had some of their ugliest internal conflicts, especially racial ones, during and right after their wars, even World War II. The unifying purposes of war metaphors could never stick anyway when the enemy included fellow Americans. All were to unite against drugs and "just say no," as Nancy and Ronald Reagan put it, but Bush defined the enemy as "everyone who uses drugs" or "sells drugs" or just "looks the other way." That included many Americans. And war required visible enemies. So the impulse to unify that stimulated pursuit of war's moral equivalent yielded divisive consequences—in the drug war, above all of white against black.

Those consequences were enhanced by the repressive course that a warlike stance sanctioned. Insofar as it arises, wartime unity derives not only from shared purpose but from clubbing war's dissidents and outsiders into conformity or invisibility; many Americans did prison or concentration-camp time in the two world wars. War sanctions the suspension of civil liberties in order to achieve unity, just as the Cold War did amid nominal peace. In the drug war, leaders highlighted the war metaphor's unifying thrust more than its repressive implications, but those surfaced in police actions, court decisions, legislative changes, property seizures, sentencing rules, the record number of men (especially African-Americans) in prison, the routine drug-testing of military personnel and much of the labor force, and the mothers of crack babies embraced by the law's long arm. They also emerged in schemes for "prisoner-of-war camps" (to be located in "large tracts of federal properties in the West" where Japanese-Americans were interned, proposed one professor; Americans can "make all the necessary adjustments. . . . We did it after Pearl Harbor"). Nor was a war mentality limited to official agencies, any more than in wartime. Private institutions also enlisted in this war. The cover of the *Yale Alumni Magazine* proclaimed "Yale's war on drugs"—a "war on a number of fronts" and involving "battlefield" conditions.[38]

Criticism of these repressive consequences, and how the war metaphor served them, did ensue. Bush's "war on drugs has become a war against the poor," complained columnist Clarence Page, "an ever-mounting assault on those"—largely black—"easiest to arrest and prosecute," even though most cocaine users were white. An "incredible pressure on the military" to wage the drug war marks "the road of militarization," worried another commentator: "It's likely to fail of a solution" and "to corrode a pillar of our democratic way of life." Stephen Chapman, conservative columnist and dogged critic of the drug war, argued that "the first casualty of war . . . is the truth. . . . The ominous images of war and plague obscure the essential fact: Drug use, unlike most crimes, is not a form of aggression against others." Bush's "military model," the *New Yorker* lamented, "identifies many millions of Americans as the enemy, dismissing them in fundamental ways from our national life." "Bellicose rhetoric," added the *Nation*, leads to a "dehumanization of the enemy," with drug dealers portrayed as "subhuman life forms," as the Japanese were in wartime propaganda. Betty Ford regretted that phrasing "our number one public health problem as a 'war on drugs' has allowed a return to the strictly punitive approach to dealing with people who are, in fact, sick." With a war presumably on, however, such criticism went mostly unheeded.[39]

The contests in the 1980s over women and abortion revealed many of the dynamics evident in the drug war. Those contests had been phrased in war's terminology long before the eighties, but its use now intensified. Reagan and Bush rarely employed it. Instead it emerged from anti-abortion forces, and then, partly in reaction, from their pro-choice opponents. Groups like Operation Rescue, founded in 1986 by ex-car salesman Randall Terry, took the rhetorical offensive in these matters. In these male-dominated organizations—women in Operation Rescue seemed to comprise a submissive "female auxiliary"—members often saw themselves as "warriors" and spun out military analogies. Planned Parenthood, in their view, was "an institution that dwarfs the Pentagon." Activist Father Norman Weslin had once been a "commander in charge of nuclear weapons" but thought "that was bush league" compared to the enemies he now faced. Terry saw feminists as "diehard enemies" and operated from "command-central" in upstate New York. Anti-abortionists' imagery, wrote critic Susan Faludi, lay in a "war-torn psychological landscape" on which "the enemy was feminism, the weapon was aggressively moralistic rhetoric, and the strategy for reclaiming the offensive was largely semantic."[40]

Pro-choice feminists sometimes dipped into the same linguistic well. Responding to the Supreme Court's 1989 decision allowing restrictions on abortion services, angry editors of *Ms.* magazine offered a cover emblazoned, "IT'S WAR!" Faludi herself, in a widely discussed book, was unsure whether to reject or embrace the war metaphor. She criticized "imagining the conflict as two battalions neatly arrayed on either side of the line," but thought "the metaphor of combat is not without its merits" and titled her account *Backlash: The Undeclared War Against American Women.* Others echoed this language in other causes: lesbian activist Susie Bright lectured on "sex wars" in which officials squashed free speech rights to sell and buy pornography; historian Lillian Faderman surveyed the "lesbian sex wars" of the 1980s; antiporn feminist Andrea Dworkin penned *Letters from a War Zone.* In matters of gender, the war metaphor knew few political boundaries.[41]

These rhetorical parries were less telling and imaginative, however, than a newer one—the antifeminists' claim that abortion constituted a crime comparable to the Nazi Holocaust, its murdered millions equivalent to the Jews and

letters against an ominous dark background: *"President Bush, Commander in Chief."* But commander in chief of what? The ad did not specify the armed forces, as if he were commander in chief of all Americans, who were obligated to follow his orders. And against whom? With no enemy abroad, at least none he wanted to engage, this was a hollow image. He had no war to wage except against Clinton and all he presumably stood for—and against Perot, whom Bush hated even more. Bush got 38 percent of the popular vote, less than any sitting President since Taft, though with Perot seizing a big chunk, Clinton fell far short of a majority. "Family values" sometimes did better—Oregon nearly ratified an anti-gay amendment and Colorado ratified a milder one, although even the GOP was divided on these matters.

The election over, Bush tried again to be commander in chief. In December he sent American troops as part of a United Nations force to feed and impose order on Somalia, ravaged by famine and civil war. Billed as a humanitarian action, this was not quite war (though it soon turned ugly), but it was notable that Bush's final act as President was to call American forces into action again, and that his first major appearance as ex-President was a trip to Kuwait, the scene of his greatest glory. Even in retirement, he remained the war President.

No other Western power had such an extensive recent record of military action—four wars in five decades, plus countless deployments, incursions, interventions, and confrontations. Would Bush's retirement break the pattern? Had the Gulf War's fickle impact already done so?

The Persisting Primacy of War

Taking office, Bill Clinton promised to "force the spring" of "American renewal." The metaphor was notable: invoking the natural rhythms of the seasons rather than the harsh logic of war marked a major change in presidential rhetoric. Unfortunately, spring's renewal soon seemed stuck in March's turbulent winds.

Clinton's challenge to militarization seemed obvious. The first President since FDR to have done no military service, as well as the first to have been born after World War II and to have significant roots in antiwar politics and culture, he had pledged economic renewal. Though chiding Bush for failing to halt the bloodshed among Yugoslavia's warring remnants, he had made it clear that foreign policy and the projection of military power abroad were not his major interests. Other Presidents had seen America as an exemplary rather than muscular city on a hill to the world, but, like Carter, Clinton seemed to mean it more ("Our greatest strength is the power of our ideas, which are still new in many lands," he announced), and he indicated that he would discard at least some relics of militarization. Although he heard "a call to service" and "the trumpets" sounding it, this was martial rhetoric in soft focus. His plan for national service, giving youngsters educational benefits in return for community service, drew on the system of duty and rewards available for military service but recognized that the latter now offered such rewards to fewer Americans.

Like his substantive positions, his style marked a change. As his seasonal metaphor indicated, it was noncombative, displaying little martial toughness, ideological rigidity, personal meanness, or partisan sharpness. He seemed the nation's patient schoolteacher, not its strutting commander in chief. Though undoubtedly at times grudging, his willingness to work with—even to be overshadowed by—Republican moderates, conservative Democrats, and ex-President Carter indicated a lack of personal vanity or a grasp of the presidency's scaled-down nature in the absence of war. Most notably, he departed from his predecessors in choosing not to present war, either in the abstract or in specific instance, as a model for tackling the nation's problems. He did not repudiate that model; like most politicians in 1993, he simply ignored it.

But if obvious, Clinton's challenge to militarization was also largely implicit, an effort to outflank it rather than attack it head-on. He had an agenda of "renewal," but neither he nor most other national figures firmly proposed to discard the old agenda, perhaps assuming it would wither on its own or under the pressure of mounting fiscal and economic problems. It did not wither on its own, however, at least not rapidly. The disadvantage of Clinton's attempt to outflank it was that he mobilized no constituency and fervor that would arrest the historical momentum of militarization. Of course, to take on its entire legacy was a daunting task in a political system that works incrementally, issue by issue, agency by agency—especially for Clinton, who, given his beliefs and experience as governor of Arkansas, had little feel for the politics and apparatus of militarization. Yet to strike only at a few parts left the legacy largely intact and allowed its advocates to concentrate their defenses, as Clinton immediately found out.

There were advantages to ignoring it—let the beast slumber and slip away rather than provoke it—but they hinged in part on the vigor and savvy, neither initially notable, with which Clinton pursued the alternatives. Perhaps Americans were so out of practice articulating any mission disconnected from war or national security that they, including Clinton, lacked the vocabulary and values for doing so. "Domestic reform without a background of overwhelming foreign crisis has not been attempted in sixty years," noted Sidney Blumenthal, but "war cannot be Clinton's paradigm."[112] Like Carter, Clinton was often accused of lacking focus—of taking on too many causes and failing to mobilize support for a few he prized highly—but as with Carter this was shallow criticism. Often it came from opponents who simply disliked the focus Clinton did have, as when they scorned him for addressing the "ban" on gays in the armed forces, much as they had Carter for granting amnesty to draft-resisters. Both also governed at transitional, postwar moments when older agendas were receding and newer ones contested, and when the presidency's power usually recedes and Congress's surges. Appropriately, Clinton rarely tried to bully

others slaughtered under Hitler. While comparisons between abortion clinics and "Nazi ovens" were apparently "commonplace" from 1960 on, they swelled in volume and authority during the 1980s, spurred partly by the abortion politics swirling around Geraldine Ferraro's nomination for the vice presidency in 1984. That year New York City Archbishop John J. O'Connor commented, "I always compare the killing of 4,000 babies a day in the United States to the Holocaust." Other bishops saw such killing as foreshadowing a nuclear holocaust. In 1983, Interior Secretary James Watt, viewing photographs of death camp corpses shown at a Holocaust conference, explained how they reminded him of aborted fetuses.[42]

These comparisons seemed bizarre: abortion was a timeless if varied practice, not a discrete and concerted event like the Holocaust, and it usually arose from individual decisions, not government mandate. Moreover, the abortion-as-genocide claim arose from elements of the religious Right and the Catholic church not noted for their concern about the fate of Jews in the Holocaust, perhaps one reason why *Christian Century* objected that the claim risked the "trivialization" of the Holocaust itself.[43] Anti-abortionists had their own reasoning, however—*Roe v. Wade* and federal policy made government at the least complicit in genocide—and the war metaphor rarely rested on users' compelling logic.

And anti-abortionists were indeed using a war metaphor, if an unusual one. To be sure, genocide sometimes occurred outside of war (as under Stalin in the 1930s), and anti-abortionists saw themselves not as dabbling in metaphor but as speaking the literal truth. Still, it was the Nazi Holocaust, not other incidents of genocide, that they usually cited. And that Holocaust was an inextricable part of World War II, both when it occurred and as Americans, with their flickering cinematic images of that war, now recalled it. Its use indicated again how World War II remained the touchstone of political imagination—a still expanding one in that Holocaust imagery was relatively new to political culture. The further Americans got from World War II, the more meaning they seemed to see in it.

Doing so in the anti-abortion crusade exposed anew the corrosive potential of the war metaphor—the vehicle it provided to express ugly emotions. Anti-abortionists did tap the urge to unify; all Americans were told to defeat an evil equivalent to that faced in World War II, when they had also united in common cause. But with the casualties so "innocent" and "human," the enemy so visible, and the divisions over gender so longstanding, the Holocaust metaphor for abortion only divided people further. No wonder that the popular radio commentator Rush Limbaugh fulminated against pro-choice "femi-Nazis"—if abortion was like *the* Holocaust, pro-choice feminists loomed as latter-day Nazis (anti-abortionists were themselves occasionally condemned as latter-day fascists).

Of course, German Nazis mostly had been men. Limbaugh's jaunty tirades

exposed not only the obvious gender politics of the abortion issue but the subtler ones of the war metaphor. Seeing feminists as waging war on fetuses, and on men—many anti-abortionists insisted that women were trampling on male privilege—inverted standard notions of gender roles in warfare. It also sanctioned some men to adopt military poses and, on occasion involving abortion, violent methods. Feminists did employ the war metaphor, but less often, and usually from a defensive posture, as if responding to a war already waged on them.

It was no coincidence that the war metaphor surged in the 1980s, when antifeminism also flourished. Despite women's growing role in the armed forces, war was still with reason regarded as a male activity. Most metaphorical wars were male-defined in inspiration and male-led in action. To frame causes as "wars," especially if women were blamed for starting them, was to see them in male terms and to place them under men's control. Many men took that logic a step further in the flourishing paramilitary culture of the 1980s, imagining a "New War" to reverse America's humiliation in Vietnam and redeem its manhood. In fantasy or simulation, paramilitary warriors fought "the battles of Vietnam a thousand times, each time winning decisively," saw "terrorists and drug dealers . . . blasted into oblivion," put illegal aliens at home and nonwhites abroad in "their proper place," got Jews "herded into canyons and shot," found that women had "to be mastered, avoided, or terminated," or wiped out homosexuals. Paramilitary culture was understandably seen as on the lunatic fringe, given the apocalyptic visions, hateful views, gun-loving mentality, and mass-murder binges accompanying it, but it overlapped mainstream culture in imagery and ideology. Restoration of "warrior dreams" and repudiation of post-Vietnam self-doubt were central to Reagan-Bush politics, to the adulation given Oliver North, and to Hollywood films of the Rambo variety that sought to replace the "soft bodies" of the 1970s (Jimmy Carter was "a 'woman' president" according to the *Wall Street Journal*) with "hard bodies" performing warrior deeds. (By the same token, Hollywood sometimes portrayed single career women as knife-wielding murderers compelling male resort to violence, as in *Fatal Attraction* [1987].) Paramilitary culture, like urban gang culture, simply offered a more striking example of how militarization was turning inward, in its case in a quite literal way that showed how the eruption of "war" among Americans was a gendered phenomenon.[44]

Gender was at issue in another "war" at the end of the 1980s, over culture and the federal government's funding of it. Backed by private lobbies, congressional conservatives like Sen. Jesse Helms inveighed against funding by the National Endowment for the Arts of artists like photographer Robert Mapplethorpe and exhibits they deemed pornographic or obscene. In many ways, this was another variant in the long struggle to contain the feminist and gay presence; most artists singled out were women (often lesbians) or gay men. Critics, and sometimes conservatives themselves, indicated that the Right had

ust discovered such people as new enemies to replace disappearing communists, but while cynical calculation was indeed involved, no new discovery was at work. Homosexuality and feminism long had been linked to communism, which was one reason why the new assault on them worked to the degree it did, although it worked in the ironic ways that had long marked such campaigns: to highlight further the presence of gays in the arts (and to make sales of Mapplethorpe's photographs soar).

Again, common phrasing of the struggle was as telling as the struggle itself. This was "a full-scale war between religious fundamentalists and the arts and museum communities," one observer noted. John Frohnmayer, the NEA chair who endured the wrath of artists for defending them weakly and of the White House for attacking them halfheartedly, subtitled his memoirs *Confessions of an Arts Warrior.* Americans were told they were waging "culture wars" whose fronts extended far beyond NEA policies. Even scholars like James Davison Hunter used the terminology literally, though admitting that America "is neither Belfast nor Beirut. (Not yet anyway.)" Just as the NEA furor peaked in 1989, another erupted over a Supreme Court decision (as it was oversimplified) protecting flag burning. No war was proclaimed—the flag was too much a war symbol to warrant such a declaration—but the passions, politics, and posturings were linked to those in the NEA struggle and the 1988 campaign: were not some artists exploiting the flag or trampling it in their exhibits?[45]

Most themes in the decade's metaphorical wars emerged in the most complex "war" of all, the one on, by, over, or against (it was hard to tell which) AIDS. War was not the sole framework enfolding AIDS, and disease had long been described in military metaphors, just as now the infectious agent HIV was seen as an "invader" which "attacks" the body's "defenses," as if a war *by* AIDS was ongoing.[46] But many uses of the war metaphor were novel and inflammatory.

They derived in part from the high rate of AIDS among gay men when the disease appeared in the early 1980s. Indeed, medical experts initially dubbed it "Gay Related Immune Deficiency" and the notion of it as a "gay plague" stuck despite its appearance among drug users, hemophiliacs, heterosexuals, and others. A decade later, the Manchester, New Hampshire, *Union Leader* still insisted that "homosexual intercourse is the genesis of every single case of AIDS" and that "anal intercourse by sodomites is the fundamental point of origin."[47]

That notion stuck because moral conservatives saw in AIDS a chance to resume the anti-gay offensive begun in the 1970s. Gay men, however, also expressed a keen sense of vulnerability to—and, as some saw it, responsibility for—the disease, and their strenuous efforts to rally their own communities and the nation tightened the association between them and AIDS, one that revived older notions of homosexuality as a medical problem. Meanwhile, other affected groups, millions of Africans for example, often lacked the political clout or even minimal respectability to command attention. A familiar American habit of finding people responsible for their own health problems also played a role in efforts to stigmatize people with AIDS; the 1970s had seen much speculation about how "Type A" personalities or "lifestyle" habits caused cancer or heart trouble. A stubborn distinction between AIDS' "innocent" and other victims further fastened on gay men the stigma of culpability. They occupied exposed ground—politically strong enough to call attention to their plight but not to control the forms that attention took.

Given the dread and the politics involved, war's metaphors issued easily, from conservatives in particular at first. As Pat Buchanan railed in 1983: "The poor homosexuals—they have declared war upon Nature, and now Nature is exacting an awful retribution." That war metaphor implied another: although "Nature" presumably had the upper hand anyway, Americans should take up arms against homosexuals. William F. Buckley called for tattooing infected people on the buttocks—reminding some of how death-camp inmates were marked in World War II—and others for locking them up. Responding to those calls, some gay men wondered if they would be incarcerated like Japanese-Americans in 1942 or worried about the "Dachau scenario," and "it was virtually an article of faith among homosexuals that they would somehow end up in concentration camps." "Out of the Baths, Into the Ovens," read a 1984 San Francisco protest sign; a gay reporter asked if officials were "preparing the boxcars for relocation."[48]

World War II, the Holocaust particularly, had found another lodgment in political culture, in a striking demonstration of how its use transcended political categories. Desperate gay men and righteous anti-abortionists had nothing in common politically—they hated each other for the most part—but they now drew from the common well of the Holocaust's example and its rising visibility in American culture. For gay men, the way had been prepared in the 1970s with the rediscovery of the mass death of gays under Nazi rule; the pink triangle worn by the Nazis' gay prisoners then emerged as a symbol of gay militancy. As metaphor or analogy, the Holocaust carried ominous and diverse implications, including prolific use by gay activists of "fascist" and "Nazi" to characterize malign politicians, health officials, or corporate leaders who presumably permitted AIDS to work its genocide, but also to assail as "sexual fascists" those gay men who supported closing San Francisco's bathhouses as a way to curb the disease.[49]

The most sustained use of the Holocaust came from writer Larry Kramer, the decade's best-known AIDS polemicist. Kramer cited the Holocaust occasionally early in the 1980s and systematically by its close—a trajectory matching the increasing scale of the disease and despair over it. Gay and Jewish, he used the Holocaust variously as metaphor, model, analog, and prophecy, in a rich and strident fashion, but above all to describe what was done *to* gay men by a homophobic society and its genocidal leaders. "AIDS is our holocaust and Reagan is our Hitler. New York City is our Auschwitz," he asserted in 1987. The Holo-

caust also illuminated for Kramer what was done *by* gay men, as he decried a "participation in your own genocide" analogous to Jews' presumed complicity in their own destruction. He pulled these thoughts together in *Reports from the Holocaust*. Others, some influenced by Kramer, offered a similar outlook. ACT-UP helped popularize the logo "Silence = Death," one of many references to the Holocaust.[50]

Kramer's angry polemics indicated how richly gay men developed war's metaphors for AIDS. In contrast, the many lesbians in this struggle rarely did, indicating gender differences again, while conservatives, less inventive and personally invested in the struggle (though closeted brethren like Terry Dolan and Roy Cohn died of AIDS), relied on rhetorical stock-in-trade. The Nazi Holocaust was only the most conspicuous among war's horrors that gay men cited, however. One used nuclear holocaust—AIDS was like an atomic bomb that fell at the "ground zero" of Manhattan, where many gay men lived. Another elaborately compared "the experience of the gay community to that of survivors of Hiroshima" in an essay "AIDS and A-Bomb Disease." Most writers evoked World War II, the Holocaust, nuclear attack or other forms of aerial war, or a potent mixture of them all—those forms of war most associated in the modern imagination with mass carnage. The film *Longtime Companion* (1990) ended by equating the joy imagined when a cure for AIDS arrived with the emotions felt at the end of World War II; the fitting title of one review was "A People at War." Or sometimes war in a generic sense was summoned up—Randy Shilts's account of the disease described "battle lines" and "the butcher's bill"—or World War I, or a third world war. Too, war language was not confined to gay men or writing about them: "Fear in the Foxholes" was an article about the burdens on health workers.[51]

Such language also appeared in memoir and fiction as well as political polemics, indicating how the war mentality was a cultural as well as political phenomenon (if that distinction held regarding AIDS). Its use by gay writers confronting AIDS was seemingly casual but in fact pointed. So Paul Monette noted in passing that "in a jerkoff scene it was very bad form to bring up one's [dead] lover, let alone the holocaust." Prefacing his poems, he wrote of "a warrior burying a warrior." Describing a dying lover, he asked, "Is this how a Jew feels when he hears 'holocaust' appropriated to some other calamity?" and speculated that "if AIDS had struck boy scouts first rather than gay men, or St. Louis rather than Kinshasha, it would have been covered like nuclear war."[52]

As with other uses of the war metaphor, those about AIDS had their share of internal contradictions, unforeseen results, and pure silliness. To write that "the bomb" of AIDS "fell without anyone's knowing the bomb had fallen" was awkward at best (few bomb explosions go unnoticed!). Kramer's assertion that "Reagan is our Hitler" did not work: Reagan lacked the necessary menace and control over his own government. Kramer's backtracking—he soon spoke of "unintentional" holocausts for which it was "not possible to locate one Hitler"—only blurred his analogy to the Nazi Holocaust. Of course, metaphors rarely meet rigid tests of historical accuracy. Their use testified to the grief and the stakes involved for gay men, and to a political culture which, despite their marginality and radicalism, they shared, one in which war metaphors were now promiscuously used.

The most pervasive metaphor regarding the disease—of a "war on AIDS"—emerged at mid-decade in efforts to galvanize federal action and spread as those efforts met a cold shoulder from the Reagan and Bush administrations. Nearer the mainstream of American rhetoric, it became commonplace in media reporting and commentary, among politicians and medical officials, and among many gay activists. "Finally tonight," Charlayne Hunter-Gault began the last segment of a *MacNeil/Lehrer Newshour* in November 1986, "we look at the latest development in the war on AIDS." That metaphor seemed especially inviting in media treatment of uniformed officials: Surgeon General Koop "makes waves in his war on AIDS," announced *Newsweek;* retired Adm. James Watkins, chair of a presidential commission on AIDS, was "drawing the battle lines on AIDS," according to another magazine.[53]

Such language reflected the pressure on government to mobilize with the energy and fiscal abandon it presumably showed in wartime. Again, World War II, and sometimes the Cold War, defined the imagination. Larry Kramer, echoing scientist David Baltimore, proposed "a Manhattan Project to deal with AIDS." Two sociologists, sidestepping the federal government's long record on health problems, offered the 1950s crash development of Polaris nuclear submarines as a model.[54]

Reagan recognized that war rhetoric sanctioned federal action on AIDS—by refusing to use it. To him, "primary responsibility for avoiding AIDS lies with the individual," whose duty was "to abstain from sex until marriage" (as if gay men should now marry, although legally they could not). Since Reagan wanted government's role in AIDS to be minimal, war rhetoric to mobilize it made no sense. Addressing the United Nations in 1988, Reagan made that clear. He saw AIDS as a "grave crisis," but regarding drugs: "We will not tolerate the drug traffickers. We mean to make war on them, and we believe this is one war the United Nations can endorse and participate in." His choices about when to use and not use the war metaphor clearly reflected his priorities.[55]

Reagan's comments, the arguments about the "war on AIDS," and the larger pursuit of war's moral equivalents all reflected the antistatist tradition of hostility toward powerful government and concerted social action. As so often before, war as analog and metaphor served to justify governmental efforts. Reluctant to defend forceful government in the interest of social or economic welfare—as if that would coddle the drug user, burden the taxpayer, reward the AIDS carrier, throttle free enterprise—Americans wrapped their demands for action in war rhetoric. Doing so, they made viable an otherwise politically untenable claim on resources and placed their demands in the one arena of na-

tional action where expense was deemed incidental, politics suspended, unity compelled, and hostility to taxation and central authority overridden. Their political culture remained remarkably like the one during the New Deal that "had yet to find a way to organize collective action save in war or its surrogate."[56]

Indeed, that was especially so in the 1980s, since Reaganism further undercut appeals for federal action grounded in social justice and economic welfare. If, after all, government was the problem, not the solution, as Reagan argued, what could justify mobilizing it into action? Only war, which presumably suspended Reagan's rule, just as national security was one item for which he refused to recognize limits. Reagan himself paid homage to that reasoning by his drug war rhetoric. As critic Susan Sontag noted:

> The transformation of war-making into an occasion for mass ideological mobilization has made the notion of war useful as a metaphor for all sorts of ameliorative campaigns. . . . Abuse of the military metaphor may be inevitable in a capitalist society . . . that increasingly restricts the scope and credibility of appeals to ethical principle, in which it is thought foolish not to subject one's actions to the calculus of self-interest and profitability. War-making is one of the few activities that people are not supposed to view 'realistically'; that is, with an eye to expense and practical outcome. In all-out war, expenditure is all-out, unprudent—war being defined as an emergency in which no sacrifice is excessive.[57]

After all, in the previous half-century, most sustained, successful actions by national government were war-related. It made sense then that new campaigns against AIDS, drugs, or other perceived threats were justified in the language of the only crusades that had proved enduring. Hence advocates of those campaigns invoked not only war generally but specific models of America's most shining success in war, like the Manhattan Project. And if models of success were drawn from war, models of catastrophe also had to be—hence the Holocaust as a model for gay men's fate.

To be sure, such uses of "war" provided cosmetic cover for political agendas quite divorced from war and national security, but their persistence was nonetheless telling. For liberals, conservatives, radicals, and reactionaries, war served to legitimate the powerful government Americans feared to admit they wanted and the huge bureaucracies they claimed to hate. Just how powerfully this distrust of government operated was suggested by Kramer's accusation that the National Institutes of Health "is drowning in waste, fraud, corruption and mismanagement. They are, in fact, pissing one billion dollars down the toilet."[58] Aside from "pissing," his rhetoric was similar to decades of conservative denunciations of national government.

The impulse to invoke war operated with special force for gays and lesbians. Their politics had been localized in the 1970s, and they lacked close ties to (much less trust in) national government and a long political tradition of their

own. Their war metaphors thus served to mobilize both government and their own community, and likewise to express distrust of the bureaucratic results at both levels. Kramer hurled the same invective of spinelessness and waste at agencies formed by his brethren, like the Gay Men's Health Crisis, as he did against the federal government, while groups like ACT-UP thrived on an antibureaucratic and antihierarchical ethos. Use of war to summon "collective action" operated both externally vis-à-vis government and internally within the gay community.

How much it galvanized action was hard to measure, since it was not the only impetus to collective effort. It also had no guaranteed effect. Reagan, vetoing a 1983 bill providing a "drug czar," showed how the war metaphor could serve different purposes: "The war on crime and drugs does not need more bureaucracy in Washington" but instead "more action in the field."[59] Still, federal funds for AIDS research, education, and treatment, like monies for the drug war, did rise sharply in the late 1980s, as did repressive actions, especially at the state level, where laws were passed or proposed to mandate tracing of sexual partners, shut gay bathhouses, permit doctors to test patients without their permission, and prosecute under criminal charges those who transmitted the disease. A lively debate, like that during war, ensued about whether to restrict individual civil liberties in order to stop the spread of AIDS. Despite their war rhetoric, most gay activists and medical experts rejected such restrictions as doomed to make HIV-infected people hide their disease and thereby impede efforts to staunch its spread. At the federal level, the trend was less coercive. Surgeon General Koop denounced punitive measures. Congress and the courts gradually applied to people with AIDS the laws and rules protecting handicapped persons in housing, employment, and health insurance. Nonetheless, coercive measures, like mandatory testing of military recruits, did emerge, as predictably did the impulse to find enemies in war. Gay activists often found them in the higher reaches of government; homophobes like Senator Helms regarded gay men as the enemy.

Though designed in part to counter distrust of government, war metaphors also showed this distrust to be deepening in the 1980s. The uses made of the Holocaust suggested that the war metaphor was becoming "appropriated by those who view themselves as victims of the state instead of its beneficiaries." No longer serving only those who wanted to mobilize the state, it now also acquired a "counter-hegemonic function." Propelling that shift were much-observed trends—a "victim" culture and a loss of faith in national government. But more may have been involved. For decades Americans had seen their government accrue in secrecy the ultimate means of destruction and had learned to fear a nuclear war in which victimization awaited the whole world. In the Vietnam War, many came to see themselves as suffering from secretive, dishonest leadership, a theme first nourished on the left but sustained by the Right, especially by those who saw a conspiracy to cover up the plight of POWs in Viet-

nam. "It is not surprising, therefore, that Americans who feel that they are not being served by their government have determined the state has secretly declared war against them." The bitter legacy of a militarized age shaped the apocalyptic uses of the war metaphor now evident.[60]

Revealing growing distrust of government, the search for war's moral equivalent also deepened that distrust. "War on AIDS," for example, provided a frail basis for mobilizing government or the gay community. Crusades grounded in war's metaphors and models, whether against poverty in the 1960s or drugs in the 1980s, tended to have limited life. Like wars themselves, they bristled with activity and then flamed out, leaving behind a substantial and often repressive bureaucratic and legal residue, and frustration that lofty goals were not met. Talk of war, after all, presumed that victory (or defeat) would follow, and in fairly short order. By 1990 Kramer was giving a lecture called "AIDS: The War Is Lost." Given his model of AIDS as war and holocaust its outcome, he had to make the story end like World War II, when victory or defeat were the only alternatives; he could hardly claim victory. As Sontag noted, the "end-of-the-world rhetoric" about AIDS "offers a stoic, finally numbing contemplation of catastrophe," just as similar rhetoric after the atomic bomb's advent had numbed the citizens that it was supposed to arouse. That a "war on AIDS" might have a different outcome (the stalemate of Korea? the futility of Vietnam?), or might just be a bad metaphor, was hard to conceive.[61]

The search for war's moral equivalent had invited government to pursue quick solutions to chronic problems resistent to speedy resolution. When the inevitable failure, waste, and repression surfaced, many Americans bewailed government's ineffectiveness, finding confirmation of the very weaknesses that had initially inspired their rhetoric. It was a cycle of raised hopes, calls for action, and ensuing disappointment that accounted for much of the cynicism about politics expressed by Americans in the Bush years.

For sure, by then war metaphors displayed such a range of sources, meaning, and gravity, however, that they seemed drained of real content, more thoughtlessly habitual than meaningful. An account of the defeat of Robert Bork's nomination to the Supreme Court was titled *Battle for Justice;* Bork himself referred to "the war to control the legal culture." Chicago mayor Richard Daley proclaimed a "war on rats," and New York mayor David Dinkins proclaimed a "war on fear"—an odd notion, since war usually stokes fear. In that vein, the *Chicago Tribune* claimed that President Bush, after a wave of bombings against civil rights leaders, "vows war on hate," although it never quoted Bush using such words. Health-related war metaphors also continued to spread: columnist Anna Quindlen scoffed at how Bush's health and human services secretary was "waging his war" on tobacco and declared herself "in favor of a War on Cigs, but a real one, with teeth." No wonder that Garrison Keillor imagined the arrest of America's last five cigarette smokers by federal agents who call in "members of a crack anti-smokers jogging unit." War metaphors were applied

to a dizzying range of issues and occasions: on its five hundredth anniversary, Columbus's landing in the Americas seemed comparable to the detonation of the first atomic bomb and a steppingstone on "the road to Auschwitz," according to historian David Stannard in *American Holocaust.* In economic affairs, too, experts found their benchmarks in war itself or its aftermath: they proposed a new Marshall Plan to rebuild East European nations freed from Soviet rule, or argued that instead "the U.S. needs a domestic Marshall Plan first."[62] Even sustained metaphors lost clarity: Were Americans waging war on AIDS, or AIDS on them? Was the enemy the virus, the politicians, the doctors, the drug companies, or the people with the disease?

Still, even thoughtless or internally contradictory uses of the war metaphor indicated how ingrained the habit had become of seeing all sorts of causes and crusades as wars. Its use could be thoughtless because no thought seemed necessary to make it work—because the assumption was automatic that "war" was the best way to mobilize Americans and to capture their problems and conflicts. At the least, such language expressed an intensity (or a longing for it) that critics overlooked when they regretted the stale character of politics: many Americans still cared fiercely about politics and government. A politics stripped of metaphor would have expressed little of that intensity. Yet political culture was hardly so uniform that alternatives to war rhetoric were unimaginable—the quilt stitched to memorialize victims of AIDS evoked images of family and folk culture quite different from those embedded in talk of war. Facing their problems, Americans did have recourse to more than the war metaphor.

That it stuck revealed how political culture remained militarized even as war itself seemed to recede. Indeed, war's remoteness to Americans was probably one reason they talked glibly of finding a substitute for it. They had little knowledge of the real thing and, as Soviet-American conflict diminished, less reason to fear it. The slippage of "war" in discourse—signifying international conflict less and less, domestic struggle more and more—was also mirrored in the reluctance of American leadership and media to designate military action abroad as war. Intervention in Lebanon, invasion of Grenada, naval action in the Persian Gulf, invasion of Panama, and the Gulf War itself usually received other labels—Desert Shield / Storm for the biggest of those actions. Almost anything was called a "war," it seemed, except war itself.

Yet even as the war metaphor reflected war's remoteness, it had the potential to make war real and viable again. The search for war's moral equivalent privileged the arena of war itself. It posited something good in war to be extracted from it and applied to other endeavors. It presumed that Americans found purpose only in war, that their state functioned effectively only in a warlike mode, and that the nation knew triumph only in warfare, with World War II still their model in that regard. But if there was something good about war, why should Americans settle for a substitute—why not the real thing, which would mobil-

ize and rejuvenate Americans even more? That was the implicit logic of the war metaphor, one that worked powerfully because it was unspoken. Soon, Americans would have a real war.

War's Last Hurrah?

President Bush did not articulate the war metaphor's logic, but instead the more familiar rules of domestic and international politics. Facing the 1990 Mideast crisis, he thought that a military solution to it would redress a grievous wrong, reaffirm America's global hegemony, reinstate war's utility for the United States, and rescue his political fortunes. As a patrician patriot, he probably thought less about his own fortunes, but "a short, successful war would be pure political gold," his aide John Sununu reportedly believed; it "would guarantee his reelection."[63] In the end, however, the Gulf War served Bush's fortunes badly and his other goals at best partially.

Hardly his doing alone, that war arose out of the Mideast's complex politics and the many American interests there that Washington's leaders perceived. Iraqi ruler Saddam Hussein was a tyrant, ruthless in suppressing minorities like the rebellious Kurds. Still, under Reagan and Bush, the United States (and others, including Britain and West Germany) had allowed economic and military resources to be given or sold to Hussein in order to reap the economic rewards involved and to have Iraq offset Syria and Iran. The Bush administration also sent Hussein ambiguous signals about his designs on the oil-rich kingdom of Kuwait, not foreseeing the form those designs would take and not wanting to antagonize a skittish ally. Iraq's invasion of Kuwait on August 2, 1990, came as a shock but also indicated that misjudgments were widespread: Kuwait had not grasped the danger; Hussein did not foresee the reaction his conquest would elicit.

Such misjudgments, the familiar prelude to war, led to a crisis involving familiar elements of power and interest. Iraq's threat to the flow of Mideast oil was real though exaggerated: to capitalize on his booty Hussein would have to sell Kuwait's oil, and only if he advanced into Saudi Arabia (a remote possibility) would he really control the region's oil. Kuwait's rich and well-placed refugee rulers and their oil-state allies leaned hard on Washington to act. So did Israel's government, long fearful of Hussein. Kuwait's regime hardly deserved rescue as a means to defend democracy, Americans' favorite reason to act, but Iraq had committed aggression across international borders, plus real and alleged atrocities in Kuwait that stirred Bush's indignation.

These familiar interests and arguments emerged, however, in a new environment. Islamic fundamentalism, though never a unitary force, made other Arab leaders nervous about confronting Hussein, who suddenly laid claim to Islamic virtue, and nervous about not confronting him. The Cold War's end neutralized the Soviet Union, long a player in the Mideast, freeing *both* Hussein

and Bush to act in ways that would have been unlikely a few years earlier. The Israeli-Palestinian conflict seemed to demand resolution, which American officials argued would be advanced by humbling Hussein.

Of all those factors, the implications of the Cold War's end most influenced Washington's leaders. They feared the loss of American hegemony now that economic power seemed more decisive than military might and that Soviet retreat undercut America's apparent need to lead its allies and to sustain its military superiority. As JCS chairman Gen. Colin Powell reportedly argued in 1989, "We have to put a shingle outside our door saying 'Superpower Lives Here,' no matter what the Soviets do, even if they evacuate from Eastern Europe." As Democratic senator David Boren worried in April 1990, "I don't think that we fully understand [that] the decline of the Soviet Union might lead to our decline as well," because other nations no longer depended on the United States to protect them. That danger seemed especially grave for Bush since he lacked a plan to revive American economic power. "I would not call [the United States] the world's policeman," he said after the Gulf crisis began, and it would not be able "to act or want to act" everywhere. "But we have a disproportionate responsibility for the freedom and the security of various countries." In fact, Bush wanted his nation to remain "the world's policeman," although he was wary of the term. Thus while American interests triggered alarm about Hussein, a deeper concern was to reassert America's role as military superpower—perhaps why Bush offhandedly told reporters, in a remark no one pursued, that he wanted the military draft renewed.[64]

Bush's concern for America's status abroad was strengthened by his wobbly political fortunes at home, where pollsters still detected pessimism about the future, and by his intuitive sense that his destiny lay abroad as America's—indeed all good nations'—commander in chief. He quickly decided to confront Hussein with military force. "This [the invasion of Kuwait] will not stand," he announced on August 5, reaching that conclusion after little consultation (apparently Powell learned of it by watching CNN news). Deployment of American forces to the Mideast went forward, though its objectives remained unclear: perhaps, in concert with economic sanctions against Iraq, it alone would force Hussein to retreat; perhaps war to dislodge him would be necessary. Arguments over which scenario should emerge dominated debate in the fall, but so too did fear that war was inevitable. Bush's "advisers say that he hasn't made a decision to go to war," one journalist reported, "but, of course, that is what they would say." Insiders leaked word that "some officials saw sanctions and diplomacy as the necessary precursors of war," with each only "'a box to check.'"[65]

Bush had announced on August 20 that "peace is more than just the absence of war." He did not spell out the "more"—the "vision thing" still eluded him—but apparently peace itself might require war. His boast after the war—"By God, we've kicked the Vietnam syndrome once and for all"—came closer to the mark. He meant that Americans were no longer afraid of going to war and mili-

tary prowess might again be the country's defining feature. He also hinted at another value in war in his many homilies and anecdotes (echoed in media coverage) about the nation's troops: war revealed the virtue and advanced the unity of Americans. To be sure, unity was usually treated by politicians and the media as a means rather than an end—needed so that Americans not again be divided in war. "It's time for America to stand together," declared Sen. Sam Nunn in January, though he opposed Congress's grant of authority to Bush to go to war. But means and ends are hard to distinguish in war: soon Bush celebrated unity as victory's product, not just its instrument.[66]

More striking than his decision to square off against Hussein was his use of World War II analogies to justify it. With Prime Minister Thatcher urging him to be Churchillian, Bush insisted that Hussein's regime, character, and threat were similar to those of Hitler before and during World War II. He often described Iraq's forces as engaged in "blitzkrieg" warfare and repeatedly cited the lessons of the 1930s: "Appeasement does not work," he told the nation; "As was the case in the 1930s, we see in Saddam Hussein an aggressive dictator threatening his neighbors," he claimed; "We're not about to make that same mistake twice," he added on August 15. Implicitly citing Hitler, he saw the world facing "another threat made by . . . a man of evil standing against human life itself." By November he was explicit: Iraqi forces did things "that even Adolf Hitler didn't do," he said, adding days later that "we do not need another Hitler in this time of our century." Hussein's fulminations about Jews added plausibility to comparisons of him to Hitler, ones also made by columnists. "If we don't check this aggression," Bush said in December, "a chance for lasting peace and for stability and security in the Gulf and a new world order will have been . . . forgone. It's that big. It's that important. Nothing like this since World War II. Nothing of this moral importance since World War II."[67]

Overestimates of Hussein's military might—especially his prospects for developing nuclear weapons—flowed logically from Bush's World War II analogy, although Bush's antiwar opponents also exaggerated Hussein's military prowess (and America's weakness). The analogy seemed to foreclose a peaceful end to the crisis—war had been necessary to stop Hitler. It also obscured the role of other nations in making Hussein a menace. His efforts to acquire nuclear weapons, like those of other nations, would have been impossible if nuclear powers had not produced such weapons in obscene volume and sold or given away much of the technology involved.

Bush's historical analogy was strained at best. It made him seem oddly naive—if Hussein was like Hitler, why had Bush failed to recognize earlier his monstrous evil? It clashed with indications that Bush might not seek to destroy Hussein's regime lest Syria or Iran rush into the vacuum—a compromise peace with Hitler was unimaginable. It did violence to the Mideast's complex politics. And it granted Hussein a historical stature that he did not warrant. Mussolini, another serious but second-rate menace with a blustery style, was a more credible analogy.

Part of the problem was that Hussein's invasion was atypical of the post-1945 world, in which aggression across international boundaries (although not civil war) had been rare, leaving World War II a plausible touchstone. Even North Korea's invasion of the South in 1950, which Bush also mentioned, occurred in a divided nation. Closer in nature, politics, and geography to Hussein's action were the various wars involving Israel or the Iran-Iraq war, but those lacked the moral or military gravity Bush wanted to see, and analogies to them were politically impossible since many of the nations involved now willingly or reluctantly joined Bush's coalition. Past wars by China against Tibet and the Soviet Union against Afghanistan were also out of bounds, since Bush sought to enlist Beijing and Moscow in his cause and Gorbachev's government was too fragile to play games with his country's history. For a man who wanted history's sanction and felt his destiny guided by it, it offered few options other than Hitler and World War II.

Strained as it was, Bush's Hitler analogy was unpersuasive to many Americans. His notion that "Saddam Hussein is worse than Hitler," reported Elizabeth Drew, "gave a number of his own advisors a headache. That Bush, a veteran of the Second World War, doesn't get it about Hitler and the feelings he still causes is puzzling."[68] Still, the analogy guided Bush, revealed his worldview, and adhered to the history of American militarization, so tied to World War II. With the Cold War's added layers peeled away, a return to the founding moment made sense.

Trying to recreate the grand alliance of World War II, Bush displayed his greatest skill in assembling a coalition to challenge Hussein. Not only did NATO allies join up, but at greater political risk Egypt, Saudi Arabia, and others, many sending major contingents to the allied force. (Israel, whose military involvement would have inflamed its neighbors, had to be kept on a short leash.) Even the Soviet Union and China said the right things, or avoided saying the wrong ones. Knitting them together was Bush himself, tireless on the telephone and in *Air Force One*, and Secretary of State James Baker, doing what he knew best, calming tempers and brokering deals. The United Nations added legal and political stature to the coalition, although it could not eliminate resentment about America playing cop on the world beat.

But this was not a repeat of the grand coalition of World War II, when the United States had footed much of the bill. Bush knew that few Americans, amid their nation's budget crisis, welcomed spending billions on war. Rich allies (Germany, Japan, exiled Kuwaitis) were tapped for the costs, which in the end they mostly covered, but the undertone of these deals was sour. Allies were treated as if cash were the price they paid for being militarily timid or incompetent, while America's armed forces seemed like mercenaries who might even accrue a profit for America's empty treasury. Bush's success in money raising underlined America's economic weakness. Its gun was to its shoulder, but its hat was in hand.

Bush pressed on, despite problems. Persuasive with allied leaders, at home

he erratically articulated his policy for stopping Hussein. "The problem isn't that he hasn't stated some reasons," Drew commented; "the problem is that he jumps about among the reasons"—oil, aggression, Hitler, and, from Baker, "jobs." "He's dealt in slogans; he's campaigned rather than explained." His image of being "steady" in international matters seemed belied, and in his campaign mode for the 1990 elections, he was again "shrill and silly," while many GOP candidates kept their distance from him. Crude outbursts—Hussein is "going to get his ass kicked"—diminished his dignity, feeding speculation that he personalized grave issues and still worried about his "wimp" image. The criticism was premature—Bush got the action against Hussein he wanted and he was "a dogged, resilient figure"—but it did speak to a brittle side of Bush that, doggedly, kept reemerging.[69]

He also pressed on despite the reluctance of seemingly natural allies. Though most conservatives rallied around Bush, they divided sharply. They split over Israel—it was "goading us to attack," fumed Pat Buchanan. The Cold War's end revealed a bigger division, as people like Buchanan lost their taste for global interventionism and decried it in some of the terms the antiwar Left a generation earlier had used. They also seemed to revert to a pre–Cold War "isolationism," though as always the term was simplistic. Many were more unilateralist than isolationist, wary of the entangling alliances Bush assembled. Buchanan heard "the Wilsonian gobbledygook we followed into the trenches of World War I—when, all the time, the hidden agenda was to pull Britain's chestnuts out of the fire." Too, many conservatives doubted Bush's fidelity to their cultural agenda, whose wars they were more eager to wage.[70]

Other conservatives assailed not only the war's necessity but its politics. Columnist Stephen Chapman condemned the conflation of "patriotism" with "militarism," the coercive belief "that the only way to support our troops is to endorse the policies that put them there," and the insistence that dissent stop once war starts: "A war that was stupid the day before it started has not become suddenly wise through the dropping of bombs and the shedding of blood. Anyone in search of the miracle of transubstantiation should look in the Catholic mass, not the Pentagon. . . . Fighting the Vietnam War would have been easier, too, without critics. Without the critics, we might still be fighting it."[71] Similar sentiments were expressed by liberals and leftists, but their emergence at the other end of the political spectrum showed how political alignments of the Cold War era were shifting.

In liberal and leftist circles, opposition was quick to emerge and substantial but also politically isolated (few could see linking arms with the likes of Pat Buchanan), offset by the fear some felt for Israel's fate, and limited by the rush of events. Its thrust was also sometimes wobbly. In their peace marches, students and older citizens (the latter bulked larger than in Vietnam protests) denounced war on Iraq and urged instead "war" on AIDS, homelessness, and poverty, unwittingly reaffirming war's utility. AIDS seemed "the forgotten war" to the *Village Voice* in February; "how can the silent, gray war in the clinic compete with TV cameras built into the heads of missiles?"[72]

That, however, was not the line usually taken by mainstream politicians who supported sanctions but criticized the rush to war. For some, the Iraq-Kuwait conflict lacked moral clarity—"A nasty little country invaded a littler but just as nasty country," said Sen. Daniel Patrick Moynihan—and the benefits of an American victory seemed murky. Moynihan also detected a subtle regression to Cold War thinking, as if "our institutions" were saying, "'Oh, my God, we missed World War III. Maybe we can have it now here.' . . . Dr. Strangelove, where are you now that we need you?" In contrast, columnist Barbara Ehrenreich foresaw not the Cold War redux but a Panama invasion writ large—which "could be in the long term just about as bad," she added, noting how the Panama operation had failed to dent the drug trade or democratize the liberated land.[73]

Even those supporting military action often condemned Bush's methods and sense of proportion. For strategist Edward Luttwak, Hussein was a "village ruffian" and "Mafia boss" typical of his region's rulers, not deserving "the wild hyperbole" of Bush's "Hitler comparison." Bush, eager to forget mounting fiscal and banking woes, operated "very much in the manner of the aristocrat still disdainful of the tradesmen pleading bills at his door as he sells yet more of the family's broad acres." Hussein's conquest of Kuwait, Luttwak argued, posed a modest problem that Bush should have liquidated by an ultimatum to withdraw, followed by bombing Iraq, rather than by assembling "an army of reconquest."[74]

Luttwak added his voice to the doubt most consistently expressed about Bush's course—not that his effort to corral Hussein was wrong but that his obsession with it, his moralizing about it, and his determination to settle it by a big war were grossly out of proportion to the issues involved and dangerously neglectful of economic problems the nation faced. "War against Iraq will be the most unnecessary war in American history," opined Arthur Schlesinger, Jr.[75] Others saw a different sign of Bush's disproportionate, or hypocritical, policy: he claimed to operate under United Nations mandate but ignored the mandates that applied to Israel's occupation of territory it had seized in war.

Among military officials, doubts about Bush's course were more muted, expressed in the measured ways expected of them. Still, by one account, the Pentagon was "the most cautious player in the Gulf policy mix" and Bush "the most hard-line." In October, JCS Chairman Powell reportedly wanted a "containment or strangulation policy," but Bush responded, "I don't think there's time politically for that strategy." War would resolve the matter; "strangulation" of Iraq might take years, although as it turned out, "strangulation" resumed once war ended. Nearly every recent defense secretary and a parade of retired officers—including former JCS chairs Adm. William Crowe and Gen. David Jones—voiced reluctance to go to war. And Gen. Norman Schwarzkopf,

who would lead the troops, publicly castigated the rush to war: given "evidence that the sanctions are pinching, . . . why should we say, 'Okay, gave 'em two months, didn't work. Let's get on with it and kill a whole bunch of people?' That's crazy."[76]

To be sure, officers' reluctance was in part a tactic to leverage a large armed force and a strong political mandate so that they could avoid Vietnam's trap and gain a sure victory. Resistance to war making often arises from specific considerations as well as flat-out principles, however, and with the military it also went beyond the moment. Powell reputedly admired Eisenhower's caution as President about making war. In pointed words for an officer who had served Reagan and Bush, Crowe publicly doubted that the question to ask was "whether Saddam Hussein is brutal, deceitful, or as Barbara Bush would put it, a dreadful man," and thought "it would be a sad commentary if Saddam Hussein, a two-bit tyrant, . . . proved to be more patient than the United States, the world's most affluent and powerful nation."[77] There was also a generational difference. World War II shaped Bush's view of war. For most military officials, Vietnam loomed larger.

It also loomed large in December and January as debate intensified about a war that now seemed inevitable. Particularly in Congress, debate was both insightful and irrelevant. It came too late, after war's engines already had been fueled, to affect the outcome, especially since Bush made it clear that he sought Congress's sanction for political reasons—to avoid a repetition of Vietnam's divisions—rather than constitutional ones, feeling free to wave aside the much-disputed War Powers Act and to make war without Congress. For their part, many Congressmen were reluctant to be counted, chiding Bush for not "consulting" them but eager to have him bear the decision-making burden. Moreover, their debate often focused on whether the circumstances for waging war against Iraq resembled those in Vietnam—"This will not be another Vietnam," Bush had promised on November 30[78]—but those circumstances were so different that this focus made it hard to address what now was at stake. And as in the Vietnam era, debate focused on whether this war could be, rather than needed to be, won. Even the striking rhetorical and substantive flair of Congress's debate seemed to lubricate the path to war, as if by being high-toned and troubled about it, Americans proved their maturity, their readiness to take on this serious burden.

The unsurprising outcome was a resolution (not a declaration of war) authorizing Bush to use force. It passed by small margins on January 12, with Congress dividing largely on partisan lines, but with Democrats like Les Aspin and Al Gore providing key support. Still, no congressional debate about going to war of this depth and division had taken place since 1917, indicating that the President no longer had quite the free hand his predecessors had wielded and that war was too serious for the nation to inch its way into it.

More often than not, however, Bush seemed simply to ignore the doubts

raised, perhaps in part because the objection most persuasive to a politician—that he risked political peril—was hardly offered. Almost everyone agreed that he would profit politically from war, at least from a quick, victorious one (a forgotten voice, George McGovern's, warned that Churchill's electoral defeat at the end of World War II "could happen to Bush").[79] It was a curious assumption given the fate of modern war Presidents, not one of whom survived politically the waging of major war (FDR, of course, died before war's surly aftermath set in). It was tied to another dated assumption—that "a President has a better chance of influencing events abroad than at home," whereas (so two political scientists argued after the Gulf War) declining "American hegemony" now meant that "other nations have the capacity to exchange influence with the White House."[80] But of course it was such decline that Bush hoped to arrest.

On January 16, 1991, allied warplanes began attacking Iraq and its positions in Kuwait, beginning what Hussein called "the mother of all battles." "The liberation of Kuwait has begun," announced the President's press secretary; this was not even to be called a "war," though if it was, Bush insisted it "started August 2," since he took no responsibility for initiating it.[81]

Allied—primarily American—aerial action dominated the war's opening weeks, and its sensational fireworks, as portrayed for and perceived by Americans at home, did much to erase the grave mood felt on war's eve. The spectacle on television of cruise missiles racing toward Baghdad, of "smart" bombs with nose cameras homing in on their targets, of Stealth bombers going into action, imparted a glitzy, high-tech dimension to the war; the formidable destruction unleashed by older B-52s rarely made it to the screen. The advent of Iraqi Scud missile attacks on Israel and Saudi Arabia was worrisome since allied forces had trouble stopping them, but they added to the video spectacular and provided a welcome touch of parity to the aerial contest—it would not be so one-sided as to render victory meaningless. The Scud attacks (and Iraq's firing and dumping of oil in and offshore Kuwait) also seemed to right the moral scales just when they threatened to tip over, offsetting criticism that allied bombing was inflicting heavy casualties on Iraqi civilians. So too did media and official complaints, recalling World War II notions of Japanese trickery, that Hussein played nasty games—piling bodies before the cameras, disguising a strategic factory as "Baby Milk Plant," billeting commanders in schools—as if propaganda and deception were outside war's rules and unknown to American war making.

Long the first resort for the United States in war, air power's use reawakened familiar themes: it would eliminate the costly ground war many feared, display anew America's superior technology, and reveal its moral superiority by securing quick victory with minimal damage. Bush stirred many of these themes in a flag-bedecked appearance before Raytheon workers who made the Patriot missiles that intercepted Scuds—patriotism, divine blessing, and technological prowess were parts of the same whole: "Thank God for the Patriot missile.

Thank God for that missile."[82] Star Wars was vindicated, he added (a judgment few experts shared).

Air power also kept war at a satisfying psychic distance for Americans, but that distance was troubling if Americans felt no sense of risk and involvement: war that was *too* easy and mechanical would be drained of the peril and passion that made it meaningful. Here, too, the Scud attacks played a vital role. As they rained down on Israel, most of them traced by television cameras, many Americans evinced a sense of vicarious participation in war, as if they were on the front lines—Tel Aviv playing in 1991 the role London had played in 1941. Stateside Americans could erase the distance and still maintain it: war's enduring remoteness was overcome in imagination even as it was sustained in reality. Not only was television coverage of the war extensive, so was the talk about it, complete with claims that this was the first television war. Since similar claims had been made about the Vietnam War, they revealed—as in that war—a need to express a closeness to war that in fact was eerily mediated by television and made strangely ephemeral by it.

The old dream of swift, sanitary, satisfying victory through air power was vindicated, according to many observers. Vengeance was wreaked on the enemy—yet not so brutally, they thought, that consciences had to be troubled, and with stunningly little loss of American lives. At times, it hardly seemed to be war but instead, as the *Chicago Tribune* described the opening aerial assaults, "the largest military air show ever displayed." "High technology," claimed reporter R. W. Apple, "sets this war apart from Vietnam," even though such technology had been celebrated in that war. When allied ground forces gained a quick victory, the stock of air power soared still higher. It was now "the *determinant of victory* in war," one cheerleading historian soon argued.[83]

But final pronouncements on its vindication were unwarranted. Allied air forces operated ably but in ideal circumstances—with overwhelming superiority, in desirable climatic and strategic conditions, against a politically isolated second-rate power, not against the Warsaw Pact armada once imagined as the enemy. For all his bluster, Hussein may never intended to wage a do-or-die war but to put up a good show and position himself as Arab martyr, although, to be sure, that may have been because allied sanctions and military power kept him from waging extended war. Lavish assessments of bombing's surgical accuracy diminished under later scrutiny, the superiority of newer weapons like the B-1 bomber over older ones like the B-52 receded, and the toll for Iraqi civilians—from direct destruction, and even more because the bombing degraded their economic, medical, and sanitary systems—was large despite the war's brevity. Too, a ground war still had to be fought and Hussein stayed in power—because the allies hesitated to topple him, but also because the bombs did not scare him away or set most of his people after him.

One war proved relatively little for—or for that matter against—air power. Still, pundits soon proclaimed the advent of "postmodern" war in which high-

tech weaponry "could minimize the shedding of American blood while maximizing the destruction on the other side"; war "now consists of short, quick actions that take days to complete, not months or years."[84] Such predictions reflected the old dream that American hegemony could proceed effortlessly. Soon, Yugoslavia's war showed distressingly few "postmodern" features. The Gulf War could be a model for future American military action only if the nation avoided most wars.

More astonishing than the air war was the triumph of allied ground forces at the end of February (though no one claimed that ground war was now ascendant). They rolled through Iraqi defenses in and near Kuwait with stunning ease, and American casualties, numbering in the dozens, had not been so light since the Spanish-American War. Indeed, the war threatened to become an unseemly massacre of Iraqis—American soldiers' descriptions of a "turkey shoot" and "shooting fish in a barrel" (phrases used to describe American action against the Japanese late in World War II) also expressed their unease.[85] The skill of Schwarzkopf and his forces, and the use of tactical air power—overlooked at the time, but more critical to victory than bombs on Baghdad—did much to account for success. So did the state of the Iraqi army, battle-tested but also badly bled after its long war with Iran; the administration's designation of it as the world's fourth-largest had been misleading (size alone hardly determines fighting ability). High-level decisions on both sides also kept the ground war short: Hussein chose not to let his army bleed long, and Bush chose not to pursue it far.

Pride, relief, and jubilation—sincere, media-stoked, and commercially exploited—washed over America after the "hundred-hour war" on the ground, as it was often called. Much of the mood involved sheer reveling in war and victory; "Desert Storm" was already becoming "Desert Party" before it was over, worried one columnist. Occasionally that included crude sentiments about the enemy; one political cartoon featured "Stormin' Norman's 4 Star Extermination" truck, with General Schwarzkopf depositing a rat into a garbage can. But the war was too short, and perhaps the memory of ugly sentiments in earlier wars too keen, to foster many dehumanizing portrayals of the enemy.[86]

The dominant mood was more diffuse and upbeat. "Bush was Caesar," Sidney Blumenthal later noted; "his popularity rating hit ninety per cent, the highest ever recorded for a President." In Washington he saluted General Schwarzkopf, "marching before thousands of lockstepping troops," while "Independence Mall was a theme park of military technology." A corollary to the celebration of military prowess was its extrapolation into the future. With the ghost of Vietnam vanquished ("It's Vietnam revisited as it should have been—Vietnam: The Movie, Part II, and this time it comes out right," commented one historian), Americans would resume their rightful place as the world's supreme warriors. Confusingly, Bush both confirmed and challenged that expectation. America's "reestablished credibility" would deter future wars, he

claimed, but added that it was "time to turn away from the temptation to protect unneeded weapons systems and obsolete bases" and noted that "even the new world order cannot guarantee an era of perpetual peace."[87]

Americans, however, rarely had gloried in military prowess as an end in itself, insisting instead that it serve higher purposes. Two seemed obvious to the war's champions in March 1991. Americans had "fought for the just and moral cause of freeing the enslaved, brutalized people of a helpless country," argued one columnist. "We came here," a serviceman wrote from Saudi Arabia, "to protect the freedom of the people of Kuwait and Saudi Arabia. Freedom is for everyone around the world, not just Americans." "Who says wars never solve anything?" asked another columnist—not those who now foresee "a new, Saddam-free Iraq," a "new Middle East order," and "real peace between Israel and her neighbors."[88]

More insistently, however, celebrants cheered what the war revealed for and about Americans rather than its benefits for other people. "In 100 hours," claimed columnist Ann McFeatters, "George Bush and his band of able assistants," and the "young men and women" abroad she applauded, "restored America's can-do spirit. . . . It felt good to win." "It is as if all the confusion and pain of recent decades have melted," noted the *New York Times*, "leaving the nation with its reassuring images from World War II intact." Conservatives who embraced the war felt vindicated: it proved the wisdom of Reagan's weapons programs. "The moral chasm between us and our enemy couldn't be a wider," a columnist added, and moral rearmament had succeeded: "We sure are doing something very right in the moral education department. We are raising men and women who are not too soft to fight when necessary, but who do not take unseemly pleasure in the suffering they must inflict."[89]

It spoke volumes about their moods that many Americans thought it took war to restore and reveal "America's can-do spirit." It exposed anew the driving element of American war making since the Vietnam era—to address Americans' sense of themselves more than their place in the world or the evils in it they sought to combat. And it revealed again how they saw their nation as able to act purposefully and effectively only in war. To be sure, policymakers also calculated power and interest, but there was no mistaking Bush's sincerity when he proclaimed on March 6 that "the brave men and women of Desert Storm . . . set out to confront an enemy abroad, and in the process, they transformed a nation at home. . . . Think about their sense of duty, about all they taught us about our values, about ourselves."[90]

Along with critics' marginalization, the war's remoteness facilitated the rush of such claims. Since "we don't have direct experience" of war, historian Robert Dallek remarked, "there's an openness about the meanings we give to it," making it "a blank slate." "We have lost some sense of the true reality of war," another expert noted, so Americans can "talk very blithely about war."[91] Of course, war's "true reality" is not necessarily combat but whatever people

experience—for most Americans, the Gulf War's reality had been the charged emotions and images it elicited. That was so less for the reasons often noted at the time—the advance of media technology or the vise of official censorship—than because of the war's brevity and ease. No new taxes or war-bond drives, no vexing inflation or shortages, no wearisome political debate or troublesome news intervened to connect stateside experience to events abroad. Only words and images remained, with which the imagination had free play.

Since war had shown America's "can-do" spirit, the process of tapping that spirit for peacetime purposes resumed. Chicago mayor Richard Daley asked President Bush to put General Schwarzkopf in charge of a renewed war on drugs: "The general would bring an attitude of 'Forget all the politicians because we're going to protect Americans first,'" Daley argued. Others soon proposed using the demobilized troops in campaigns against crime, drugs, illiteracy, or poverty. Democratic senator Tom Daschle had "this dream," as the *New York Times* paraphrased it: "Now that the war is over, the Government and the news media begin to focus on domestic problems with the same intensity they gave the Persian Gulf." Economist Robert Reich, soon to join Bill Clinton's Cabinet, urged a "vast investment" in America's work force: "It needs the political equivalent of a warrior like Gen. Norman Schwarzkopf to propose a plan for rebuilding America, as Gen. George Marshall did 44 years ago for rebuilding Western Europe."[92]

Bush seized this line of reasoning as avidly as anyone, though bending it to different purposes. Noting the Gulf War's "clear-cut objectives" and "overriding imperative to achieve results," on March 6 he lectured the cheering luminaries assembled in Congress and the millions of Americans watching on television: "We must bring that same sense of self-discipline, that same sense of urgency, to the way we meet challenges here at home." He urged passage of his major domestic initiatives, a crime bill and funding for road construction: "If our forces could win the ground war in 100 hours, then surely the Congress can pass this legislation in 100 days." If Americans could "selflessly confront evil" abroad, he added, "then surely we can make this land all it should be."[93]

Yet by April the euphoria—and Bush's popularity—were dissipating. Even at the moment of victory, Bush had seemed out of focus—eager to celebrate but also at loose ends, as he had been at the end of the Cold War. Reporters again noticed that he seemed "somber," and Bush admitted, "I haven't yet felt this wonderfully euphoric feeling that many of the American people feel." He was pleased by "a new, wonderful sense of patriotism" and happy that "there isn't any antiwar movement out there." But sensing something missing, he pointed to "World War II; there was a definitive end to that conflict."[94] He had in mind the Mideast's unresolved problems but also seemed restless without a war to wage.

His immediate problem was that war's achievements turned out to be limited and his leadership again lackluster. His decision to let Hussein stay in

power and to backpedal from noisily urging Iraqis to overthrow him mocked his earlier claim that Hussein was Hitler's moral equal. His reluctance to intervene on behalf of Shiites and Kurds, who had rebelled against Hussein and suffered mightily at the hands of his army, raised the same problem (similar to Eisenhower's when he sat out the 1956 Hungarian revolution). Bush's inaction unleashed a torrent of moral indignation against him and suggested that the man who had "kicked the Vietnam syndrome" now was gripped by it himself. The spectacle of Kuwait's returning rulers casting out thousands of Palestinian and other guest workers tarnished his claim to have liberated that country. No "new world order" took shape and it was unclear whether Bush had any idea what it would entail, beyond continued American hegemony; he soon discarded the phrase. The promise that victory would help resolve Israeli-Arab conflict also seemed exaggerated. The Iraqis had been thrown out of Kuwait, but other than that this moral equivalent of World War II had ambiguous results.

The ensuing letdown was in good part Bush's fault. His World War II analogy set up Americans to expect total victory, something he was unable or unwilling to deliver. Perhaps admirable by other criteria, his caution regarding further intervention in Iraq—soon continued under United Nations aegis, but only to protect Kurds in a northern enclave—failed the test of his own rhetoric.

The presumed moral and military efficacy of America's war making also receded in the spring. Bush's pre-August policy of appeasing Hussein met tough criticism. Reassessment also focused on the necessity of slaughtering so many Iraqi soldiers—one hundred thousand dead and three hundred thousand wounded by Defense Intelligence Agency estimates—and on the damage to conditions for Iraqi civilians (it was clear they were not liberated). Praise for American weaponry also became more muted. Most of the bombs, it turned out, had not been the precision-guided ordnance featured in media coverage, and some glitzy weapons like the Patriot (actually an older technology) had performed less ably than thought. This was no "antiseptic Nintendo game" or "surgical war," concluded one early review; "it was a slaughter." Meanwhile, some of Hussein's atrocities were verified but others turned out to be trumped up, by the propaganda machine of Kuwait's exiled rulers, among others. Nor did the carping come only from the antiwar Left. The war's conservative opponents weighed in again, and NBC's low-key John Chancellor, writing in the *New York Times*, acidly commented on earlier predictions that "Iraq might actually use fuel-air explosives, a horrible weapon of almost nuclear potency. When the fighting began, the country that did use fuel-air explosives was the U.S., and nobody complained."[95]

Reassessment usually follows wars; whether it discredited this war was in the eye of the beholder. But because praise of American war making had soared so high and then the war ended so quickly, reappraisal rubbed the luster off this victory more quickly than after most wars. A squabble between Bush and his generals dulled it more. Bush was reportedly pounding the table in fury at reports that they had resisted his recourse to war and that he had halted their march through Iraq short of the final blow to Hussein's forces. Schwarzkopf, in a celebrated television interview, claimed that his "recommendation had been . . . continue the march. I mean, we had them in a rout," though in February Powell had apparently regarded a further rout as "unchivalrous."[96] Vietnam still echoed: once more, it seemed, a civilian had denied the generals victory.

Indeed, the demise of the "Vietnam syndrome" seemed prematurely declared. The POW/MIA mythology continued to fester, with Bush himself accused by an angry crowd of not doing enough to find Americans in Vietnam (and, as CIA director, of participating in the alleged cover-up). More than that, the Gulf War had been too unlike the Vietnam War to prove much; brevity was both its virtue and its limitation in that regard. Bush himself had noted before it began that if it were long, "I think support would erode, as it did in the Vietnam conquest—I mean, conflict."[97] Aside from that notable slip of the tongue, Bush indicated the limits of burying Vietnam—what if protracted war occurred again? Just such a war seemed to loom with Hussein still dealing out misery to Kurds and others, and soon when Americans considered intervention in Yugoslavia's civil war. Like most of them, Bush was gun-shy.

There was more to Bush's problems than war's murky aftermath and his ineptitude dealing with it, however. The very elements of this war that elicited jubilation also robbed it of lasting satisfaction and significance. The ease of victory, against an enemy seemingly reluctant to fight and incompetent when it did, stripped the war of that gravity of sacrifice and achievement that embeds a war in language and memory and establishes it as a model of concerted national action. The war soon seemed transient, forgettable—not *substantial* enough to change the course of the nation and the world. Bush had asked Americans to see it like World War II, but it lacked such meaning for them. It was a fantasy war seen on television, with all the staying power of a television show—vivid as long as the screen flickered, gone once the television sets were turned off. It lacked legs—in politics, diplomacy, economics, even the imagination.

So the language and analogies it spawned turned out to be few and fleeting. Hussein's phrase "the mother of all battles" sparked a flood of jokes, then vanished. One of many products keyed to the war, Desert Shield Condoms ("designed with the hardened veteran in mind") lacked commercial staying power.[98] By the summer of 1991, the calls (never numerous anyway) to turn the Gulf War's spirit toward stateside problems faded, although Bush persisted with them. The war metaphor itself was oddly absent, at least its inspirational form calling for governmental action, not so much dispelled as bankrupted by real war. The Gulf War was sufficient to debase its old currency but insufficient to issue a new one.

The war's unifying effects also proved transient. Bush and others celebrated

those effects, especially among American soldiers, but unity dissolved as soon as war ended. Bush himself was deaf to the social issues involved. Asked in December 1990 whether "a disproportionate number of U.S. troops stationed on the front line hail from minorities and the working class," he had given an angry, incomprehensible answer.[99] Even buoyed by victory, he only uttered platitudes about not hating each other.

Again, the fault was not his alone: war is a bad healer. In this case, conservatives took the lead in rubbing old wounds, either resenting how the war had set aside their cultural agenda or emboldened by the war to advance it anew. They resumed their attack on abortion, the NEA, gay rights, and "political correctness." In April, columnist George Will captured the thrust of this attack when he linked the Gulf War to the "low visibility, high-intensity war" against the Left waged by Lynne Cheney, the NEA chair and defense secretary's spouse. She "is secretary of domestic defense. The foreign adversaries her husband, Dick, must keep at bay are less dangerous, in the long run, than the domestic forces with which she must deal. Those forces are fighting against the conservation of the common culture that is the nation's social cement."[100] Precisely the attitude that Barry Goldwater had long feared seemed more baldly than ever at the surface of American life.

The new fury over political correctness was rich with history, irony, and obfuscation. A struggle over "PC" activism had gone on for years, another skirmish in the supposed "culture wars" of the 1980s. If political correctness had any meaning, it involved efforts to develop multicultural curricula in schools and to ban "hate speech" at some college campuses. To its critics, it comprised the sweeping agenda of a monolithic, feminist-dominated Left, although in few places was it a decisive force, since those deemed to be on the left disagreed mightily with each other.

Nonetheless, Bush condemned the Left's "boring politics of division and derision," the very politics he had practiced, and conservatives saw their backs to the wall after a decade of Republican rule and a war many had championed. They inveighed against the Left's ideological rigidity after years of hardening their own test of politicians' views on abortion and other issues, and just when the Left was in disarray. Though "really a marginal movement," political correctness was "treated as if it's what universities are all about," one university official correctly noted, and despite its alleged power, it met attack from mainstream media and liberal intellectuals as well as conservatives. Critics were also humorless, failing to recognize that "political correctness" was an in-joke used by liberals and leftists to chide each other and lament their differences.[101]

But this struggle had long confounded all parties. Few in 1991 recognized that its renewal was partly linked to the Gulf War: to its passions and sour aftermath; to the return of rituals like flag waving and homecoming parades evoking an earlier era of white male dominance; to victory over an Arab enemy and by implication over non-Western values; and to the Left's marginality during

the war. Operation Desert Storm preceded "Operation Campus Storm," noted one of the few astute observers of the controversy, arguing that the Western culture defended by conservatives as timeless and apolitical was in part a product of ideological mobilization during the world wars. Failing to see such things, all parties paid homage to the Gulf War's curious transience—they talked as if the war had never happened, but acted very much as if it had.[102]

To be sure, war's satisfactions did not immediately vanish. In June 1991, victorious troops marched down Manhattan's streets, greeted by "a magnificent blizzard of ticker tape, patriotism and affection." *Time* took that occasion to reaffirm that even if "the gulf still burns," what was important was not how the war changed the Mideast but how it changed "the way Americans think about themselves and what their country has achieved by war." Perhaps "the great postwar party now in progress is more a mark of national maturity than of smugness and jingoism." As *Time* defined it, "maturity" included Americans' willingness to go to war, leavened by their "healthy cynicism about the chance of bringing lasting peace to an ancient war zone." Above all, the celebrants cheered "the return of American competence." The war, according to one public opinion expert, banished Americans' doubt about their economic and technological prowess "in a profound way that will be long lasting, well past the year 2000." Yet coverage of the "postwar party" was strained. *Time*'s editors felt enjoined to explain why the party lasted longer than the war itself, which "didn't amount to a bad weekend in Vietnam," one veteran of that war noted. Covering his city's parade, a *New York Times* reporter alternated purple prose about the exultation with acid comments—that, for example, "many Americans could not find triumph in the conquest of a nation with the gross national product of Kentucky."[103]

June's celebrations were faded memories when the next furor broke out, this one pitting two black Yale Law School graduates against each other. Bush's nomination of Clarence Thomas to the Supreme Court was under fire but apparently destined to prevail until Thomas's former subordinate, Anita Hill, reluctantly brought charges of sexual harassment against him. The Senate Judiciary Committee's hearings in October stirred a potent brew of racial, gender, and sexual issues. The following spring saw much of Los Angeles aflame in a riot triggered by the acquittal of policemen accused of assaulting black motorist Rodney King. The riots raised the specter of "race war," though most Americans, having used war as a metaphor for other issues, avoided it with regard to their deepest social division. Moreover, that division seemed more complex, no longer a simple black-white fissure as rioters displayed many colors and blacks and Latinos took after Asian-Americans as well as whites.

Both ugly moments were treated, wrongly, as detached from the Gulf War and militarization's course. The war had colored gender relations, yielding familiar renderings of war as a male arena. During autumn's build-up of forces, the media had noted the role of women in the armed forces and as expert com-

mentators, but once "the serious business of combat had begun," women "slid further off the page; only their yellow ribbons caught the public eye." (In a big *Chicago Tribune* photo wrap-up on the war, only three military women, one cradling a teddy bear, appeared among the pictures of heroic men, and no women on the enemy's side.) The victory celebrations were largely a male affair, focused on the American potency presumably shown in the war. No direct line ran between those moods and events to follow—the Hill-Thomas hearings and the Tailhook affair, in which male navy personnel assaulted fellow servicewomen. Yet every modern American war had strengthened proscriptions on or hostilities to women. It seems unlikely that this war was an exception, though its brevity limited its force in that regard. The war did lead to another expansion of women's roles in the armed forces, but the military's goal seemingly was "to absorb just enough of the changes in women's expectations and influence to permit it to use women without drastically altering its own political mission"—or gender inequalities generally.[104]

Connections to the Gulf War were more obvious in the case of the Los Angeles riots. The area was reeling from defense cutbacks that soured the outlook of many social groups. Lakewood's white middle-class residents had rested their livelihoods and their sense of purpose and place on McDonnell Douglas ("It's a town on the plantation model," one local noted, "Douglas being the big house"). In the shadow of corporate "cathedrals of the Cold War," they "believed their companies to be consecrated to what they construed as the national interest, and to deserve, in turn, the nation's unequivocal support." When the defense boom went bust, "it was their adolescent males, only recently the community's most valued asset, who were most visibly left with nowhere to go" and found a substitute in the Spur Posse gang that terrorized local children and abused girls sexually.[105]

Most black Angelenos had less far to fall but also less to cushion the blow, and even more reason to contrast their plight to the triumphal mood unleashed by the war. True, General Powell was hailed as showing what black men could achieve. President Bush asked West Point cadets to look around them: "People divided by race and religion? No." In fact "the military," Powell showed, was "the greatest equal opportunity employer around."[106] But beyond the hint of tokenism in that statement, as the military shrank, it offered fewer opportunities for poor and minority men and women, and its example no longer guided other institutions—what had once been a mighty beachhead for racial progress now seemed a remote outpost. That American leaders extolled racial equality in the military still sent the disturbing message that equality counted there because it served national power, and elsewhere was less important. And of course race riots had accompanied most American wars, each heightening the tension between the declared pursuit of freedom abroad and tolerance of inequalities at home. Now, however, that tension arose in straitened fiscal and political circumstances, whereas post–World War II abundance had underwritten racial reform. The fortunes of African-Americans were troubled for many reasons, but among them was the dissolution of the Cold War that had provided them political and ideological leverage. The result was the spectacle of billions spent to free Kuwait's rulers from exile, while pockets were declared empty for Americans' mounting problems—a contrast pointed out by some Los Angeles rioters and victims (and again when Hurricane Andrew devastated Florida in 1992 and floods swept the upper Mississippi valley in 1993).

Yet the connections between war and Americans' internal difficulties were fewer, thinner, and briefer after the Gulf War than in the aftermath of earlier wars, and not only because of its brevity. Despite the war, militarization—as state policy if not state of mind—was slowly contracting, no longer providing an arena of the size it once had for making such linkages. The Gulf War's aftermath thus exposed the autonomy of issues of race, gender, and other social divisions—as issues in themselves, not just as matters to settle in order to strengthen national power. Those issues always had that autonomy, of course, just as their connections—being ones of perception as much as reality—to militarization hardly disappeared in 1991. Still, the overriding framework that national security once provided—for Truman's order desegregating the armed forces, for example, or even for conflict over feminism in the 1970s—was not there. Insofar as militarization still defined Americans' internal conflicts, it did so less because of its dominating presence than because of its distasteful residue—of emotions, words, and, especially for regions that once thrived on militarization, economic woes.

The Gulf War also exposed Bush's political weakness: He "was a war President unlike any other since Polk; all the rest, from Lincoln through Nixon, had consistently believed in the efficacy of government." Bush's Reaganesque denial of that efficacy at home "after deploying the military abroad was the very soul of contradiction," and one reason that the war brought him "a victory from which he never recovered." His popularity collapsed when he seemed to have no idea what to do without a war. A mission was not hard for many Americans to envision—solutions to problems of debt, competitiveness, and health care were often mentioned—but Bush could not engage these issues. As recession continued and trade and budget deficits swelled, he floundered. Since the war had established him as a strong leader, critics asked why he did not lead at home. As an administration official said after the 1992 election: "Voters thought he was very effective" in foreign policy. "If he wanted to, he could solve their problems. When he didn't, it made them resentful." Bush came across as callous; clearly he had the capacity to lead (look at the war!) but did not care to do so at home. War had "inflated the illusion of omnipotence—and then punctured it."[107]

He kept trying, but his State of the Union address in January 1992, billed as the occasion to restart his presidency, failed to do so. He issued familiar injunctions to remain strong: "We cannot repeat the mistakes made twice in this cen-

tury, when armistice was followed by recklessness and defense was purged as if the world were permanently safe." Continued if more prudent militarization was his opening theme. Then, in an oddly indifferent way—"And now to our troubles at home"—he shifted to the nation's economic troubles but could not leave war behind: "I know we're in hard times. But I know something else. This will not stand," the last phrase being his line after Iraq's invasion of Kuwait (he repeated it near the end of the address). He tried to use the Gulf War to build support for his economic programs: "We can bring the same courage and sense of common purpose to the economy that we brought to Desert Storm. And we can defeat hard times together." If Congress failed to pass his legislation by March 20, then "the battle is joined." But invoking the Gulf War did not work. That war seemed almost forgotten, and many Americans, accurately or not, thought Bush had no program for dealing with economic problems.[108]

Those troubles involved a mild, meandering recession which the war's confidence-building victory did not halt. In the long run, they were also global—other Western economies were faltering, many more than America's—and structural, tied to ebbing defense outlays. The war strengthened the Pentagon's claim on the defense budget, whose decline after the mid-1980s was slower than after the Second, Korean, and Vietnam Wars, but dependence on defense monies was now more entrenched and regionally concentrated, so that the cumulative effects of even modest declines mounted, above all in California. Politicians and regional interests accepted the broad drift of demilitarization but sought damage control for their districts, so that politics focused on redistributing the pain, not on underlying dynamics. In 1992, Bill Clinton and billionaire independent candidate Ross Perot addressed those dynamics, but cautiously in Clinton's case, erratically in Perot's. Bush added to his problems by pretending there was no issue, leaving him in a political no-man's land: he could hardly blame economic woes whose existence he denied on a course of demilitarization he refused to admit was being taken.

All he could do was assail Democrats for fiscal imprudence and failure to pass his legislation, and return to the "culture war." That meant an awkward alliance with Pat Buchanan, his foe in the GOP primaries. "All the institutions of the Cold War," Buchanan had said in announcing his candidacy, "must be reexamined," a bolder declaration than any Democrat made. As for Bush, "He is yesterday." But Buchanan wanted to redeploy those institutions to the culture war as much as dismantle them. In May he heard the sounds of the Los Angeles rioters as "the authentic laughter of the barbarian"—comparable to noises once made by Nazi "Brown Shirts" and communist "Red Guards"—and charged that privileged forces sought to destroy "Judeo-Christian culture." He admired General Schwarzkopf and his troops, but "as America's imperial troops guard frontiers all over the world, our own frontiers are open, and the barbarian is inside the gates." At the GOP convention in August, Bush operatives desperate for allies gave Buchanan a national stage. He proclaimed "a religious war" and "a cultural war, as critical to the kind of nation we shall be as the Cold War itself, for this war is for the soul of America." In it, Bill and Hillary Clinton "are on the other side, and George Bush is on our side." Just as troops had retaken Los Angeles's streets after the riots, "we must take back *our* cities, and take back *our* culture and take back *our* country." Others were no less pointed: keynoter Phil Gramm and evangelist Pat Robertson compared Clinton and the Democrats to communists; denunciations of gay rights and paeans to "family values" were routine (but music from Broadway's gay-themed *La Cage aux Folles* swelled as the Bush and Quayle families marched to the podium).[109]

"By virtue of his political weakness," Bush "found himself waging a Kulturkampf that autumn," despite evidence that it had backfired at the convention. Since Buchanan was a poisonous figure, Bush made Dan and Marilyn Quayle his deputy commanders. "The only combat Dan Quayle ever experienced was in the Kulturkampf," but in it "he proved a hero." Like other Republicans, the Quayles worked a vague but charged divide: foes of the Vietnam War, gays and feminists and single mothers, and the "cultural elite" (though Quayle's publishing family belonged to it) were responsible for everything from economic decline to the poverty of children to Los Angeles's racial cauldron. Despite his own office and twelve years of GOP rule, Quayle saw himself as "playing David to the Goliath of the dominant cultural elite." The thrust of conservatism was never more evident: war abroad was for show, war at home was serious; enemies abroad were secondary, those at home more dangerous; American decline was a fiction pedaled by America-bashers, though they were also responsible for it; needed was "not just economic, not just political, but cultural change," as Quayle put it. In retirement, Barry Goldwater, backing a gay-rights law for Phoenix and women's right to abortions (they have "been going on ever since man and woman have lived together"), saw his estrangement from conservatism's dominant wing deepen.[110]

As part of their "Kulturkampf," Bush and his allies "waged generational war." He "used the Second World War and the Cold War as his reservoirs of experience for attacking Clinton as draft dodger and Moscow tourist." On occasion he pulled from those wars something positive, offering a "G.I. bill for kids" to help families pay for children to attend private schools, awkwardly comparing it to the 1944 GI Bill (only if kids were veterans of the "culture war" could this analogy work). More often those reservoirs spewed poison. One Bush friend on the campaign trail, tapping Cold War images of homosexuality (and canceling out Clinton's image as womanizer), called Clinton "a sissy. . . . You can tell how he walks. . . . Watch as he kind of swishes his rear end."[111] Bush raised the specter of a future war—though all candidates dealt gingerly with the ongoing one in Yugoslavia—to charge that Clinton lacked the experience and manliness to be president.

Finally, Bush ran as commander in chief. His television ads late in October featured scenes from the Gulf War and his leadership in it, and ended, in white

letters against an ominous dark background: *"President Bush, Commander in Chief."* But commander in chief of what? The ad did not specify the armed forces, as if he were commander in chief of all Americans, who were obligated to follow his orders. And against whom? With no enemy abroad, at least none he wanted to engage, this was a hollow image. He had no war to wage except against Clinton and all he presumably stood for—and against Perot, whom Bush hated even more. Bush got 38 percent of the popular vote, less than any sitting President since Taft, though with Perot seizing a big chunk, Clinton fell far short of a majority. "Family values" sometimes did better—Oregon nearly ratified an anti-gay amendment and Colorado ratified a milder one, although even the GOP was divided on these matters.

The election over, Bush tried again to be commander in chief. In December he sent American troops as part of a United Nations force to feed and impose order on Somalia, ravaged by famine and civil war. Billed as a humanitarian action, this was not quite war (though it soon turned ugly), but it was notable that Bush's final act as President was to call American forces into action again, and that his first major appearance as ex-President was a trip to Kuwait, the scene of his greatest glory. Even in retirement, he remained the war President.

No other Western power had such an extensive recent record of military action—four wars in five decades, plus countless deployments, incursions, interventions, and confrontations. Would Bush's retirement break the pattern? Had the Gulf War's fickle impact already done so?

The Persisting Primacy of War

Taking office, Bill Clinton promised to "force the spring" of "American renewal." The metaphor was notable: invoking the natural rhythms of the seasons rather than the harsh logic of war marked a major change in presidential rhetoric. Unfortunately, spring's renewal soon seemed stuck in March's turbulent winds.

Clinton's challenge to militarization seemed obvious. The first President since FDR to have done no military service, as well as the first to have been born after World War II and to have significant roots in antiwar politics and culture, he had pledged economic renewal. Though chiding Bush for failing to halt the bloodshed among Yugoslavia's warring remnants, he had made it clear that foreign policy and the projection of military power abroad were not his major interests. Other Presidents had seen America as an exemplary rather than muscular city on a hill to the world, but, like Carter, Clinton seemed to mean it more ("Our greatest strength is the power of our ideas, which are still new in many lands," he announced), and he indicated that he would discard at least some relics of militarization. Although he heard "a call to service" and "the trumpets" sounding it, this was martial rhetoric in soft focus. His plan for national service, giving youngsters educational benefits in return for community

service, drew on the system of duty and rewards available for military service but recognized that the latter now offered such rewards to fewer Americans.

Like his substantive positions, his style marked a change. As his seasonal metaphor indicated, it was noncombative, displaying little martial toughness, ideological rigidity, personal meanness, or partisan sharpness. He seemed the nation's patient schoolteacher, not its strutting commander in chief. Though undoubtedly at times grudging, his willingness to work with—even to be overshadowed by—Republican moderates, conservative Democrats, and ex-President Carter indicated a lack of personal vanity or a grasp of the presidency's scaled-down nature in the absence of war. Most notably, he departed from his predecessors in choosing not to present war, either in the abstract or in specific instance, as a model for tackling the nation's problems. He did not repudiate that model; like most politicians in 1993, he simply ignored it.

But if obvious, Clinton's challenge to militarization was also largely implicit, an effort to outflank it rather than attack it head-on. He had an agenda of "renewal," but neither he nor most other national figures firmly proposed to discard the old agenda, perhaps assuming it would wither on its own or under the pressure of mounting fiscal and economic problems. It did not wither on its own, however, at least not rapidly. The disadvantage of Clinton's attempt to outflank it was that he mobilized no constituency and fervor that would arrest the historical momentum of militarization. Of course, to take on its entire legacy was a daunting task in a political system that works incrementally, issue by issue, agency by agency—especially for Clinton, who, given his beliefs and experience as governor of Arkansas, had little feel for the politics and apparatus of militarization. Yet to strike only at a few parts left the legacy largely intact and allowed its advocates to concentrate their defenses, as Clinton immediately found out.

There were advantages to ignoring it—let the beast slumber and slip away rather than provoke it—but they hinged in part on the vigor and savvy, neither initially notable, with which Clinton pursued the alternatives. Perhaps Americans were so out of practice articulating any mission disconnected from war or national security that they, including Clinton, lacked the vocabulary and values for doing so. "Domestic reform without a background of overwhelming foreign crisis has not been attempted in sixty years," noted Sidney Blumenthal, but "war cannot be Clinton's paradigm."[112] Like Carter, Clinton was often accused of lacking focus—of taking on too many causes and failing to mobilize support for a few he prized highly—but as with Carter this was shallow criticism. Often it came from opponents who simply disliked the focus Clinton did have, as when they scorned him for addressing the "ban" on gays in the armed forces, much as they had Carter for granting amnesty to draft-resisters. Both also governed at transitional, postwar moments when older agendas were receding and newer ones contested, and when the presidency's power usually recedes and Congress's surges. Appropriately, Clinton rarely tried to bully